

JOHN THOMPSON & C.E. HIRSCHAUER

I Can I Will

the story of John Thompson

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I CAN I WILL

One Man's Journey Through Loss, Faith, and Never
Giving Up

*Developed from the life story of John Thompson Composed by
C.E. Hirschauer*

*A memoir of survival, humor, faith, family, and the refusal to stay
down.*

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Dedication

This book is dedicated to my wife, Genie, whose love carried me through every storm.

To my daughters, who gave me countless reasons to keep fighting.

To my parents, who taught me that character is built by showing up, working hard, and never quitting.

To my family and friends, whose love, prayers, and unwavering support carried me through the darkest chapters of my life.

To every doctor, nurse, therapist, prosthetist, caregiver, and recovery mentor who walked beside me when I couldn't walk alone.

To the Lost Limb Riders, my brothers and sisters on the road, who showed me that losing a limb doesn't mean losing your life.

And to every amputee, every survivor, every person battling addiction, illness, grief, fear, or despair—

This book is for you.

If you're wondering whether you have one more step left in you...

You do.

I Can.

I Will.

And so can you.

Foreword

My name is **John Thompson**.

If you're holding this book, thank you.

It means our paths have crossed, even if we've never met.

For most of my life, I never imagined I'd have a story worth telling. I was just a working man trying to provide for my family, put in an honest day's work, and take life one day at a time. I wasn't looking to inspire anyone. I was just trying to make it through.

Then life started testing me.

I've survived serious illness, addiction, the loss of loved ones, a heart attack, cancer, and the amputation of my right leg below the knee. More than once, I found myself wondering if I had anything left to give.

Every time I was knocked down, I faced the same choice.

I could stay where I was.

Or I could get back up.

This book is the story of choosing to get back up.

It isn't a story about perfection. I made mistakes. I failed. I hurt people I loved. I lost my way more than once. But I also learned that failure doesn't have to be the end of your story unless you decide to stop writing it.

Along the way, I discovered that no one survives life's hardest moments alone. My wife, Genie, my daughters, my family, my

friends, my faith, and an incredible community of people carried me when I couldn't carry myself. Their strength became my strength until I could stand on my own again.

These pages aren't meant to make you feel sorry for me. They're meant to remind you that hope is still possible, even when it feels out of reach. That laughter still exists in the middle of pain. That purpose can be found after loss. And that some of life's greatest victories begin on the days when getting out of bed feels impossible.

If you're facing your own battle—whether it's illness, addiction, grief, fear, or simply a season where life has become heavier than you ever imagined—I hope you find something here that reminds you to keep going.

You don't have to be fearless.

You don't have to have all the answers.

You just have to take the next step.

That's all I ever did.

And somehow, one step at a time, it was enough.

No matter what life throws at you...

I Can.

I Will.

And so can you.

Author's Note

I never set out to write a book.

For a long time, I convinced myself that nobody would care about my story. I was just a working man who got knocked down more times than most. There wasn't anything special about me. I wasn't a celebrity. I wasn't famous. I wasn't trying to inspire anyone.

I was just trying to survive.

Then I thought back to the darkest moments of my life.

The hospital rooms.

The sleepless nights.

The fear.

The addiction.

The cancer.

The amputation.

The mornings when I wasn't sure I had enough strength to face another day.

If, during those moments, someone had handed me the story of an ordinary man who had walked the same road and made it through, I would have read every word. Not because I was looking for a hero, but because I was looking for hope.

That's why this book exists.

This isn't the story of a perfect man. It's the story of a flawed one. I made mistakes. I hurt people I loved. I lost my way. I questioned my faith. I fell down more than once.

But every time I fell, I made a decision to get back up.

Some days I did it with confidence.

Most days I did it because quitting simply wasn't an option.

Everything you'll read in these pages comes from my life. The people are real. The events are real. The victories are real. So are the failures. Nothing has been written to make me look better than I was. If anything, I've tried to be harder on myself than anyone else ever could be.

Some conversations have been recreated from memory, and some events have been compressed for the sake of storytelling, but every chapter reflects the truth of what I lived and what those experiences meant to me.

If parts of this book make you laugh, laugh.

If they make you cry, that's okay too.

If they make you stop for a minute and think differently about your own life, then this book has done its job.

Read it however you want.

Take what helps you.

Leave what doesn't.

But if you remember only one thing after you've turned the last page, I hope it's this:

No matter how dark today feels...

No matter how many times life knocks you down...

You can get back up.

I did.

And so can you.

— John Thompson

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "John A. Thompson". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "John" being more prominent and the last name "Thompson" written in a more compact, cursive style.

1

Chapter 1: Growing Up

My father woke up at 4:30 every morning.

I'd hear his boots hit the floor before the sun even thought about coming up. The floorboards in the hallway creaked in the same spot every time — third board from the bedroom door. Then the coffee pot would start perking, and the smell would drift back to my room. That's how I knew it was time to get up, even on Saturdays.

He was a maintenance worker for the city of Grinnell. Mowers, tools, grease, grass clippings that stuck to his forearms like glitter you couldn't wash off. He came home with dirt under his fingernails and grease embedded in his knuckles. I watched him leave for work in the dark and come home in the dark, day after day, year after year. He never complained about it. He never asked if it was fair. He just did what needed to be done.

Once, he took me along on a Saturday. The place was the city shop — not loud like a machine shop, but full of the hum of equipment waiting to be fixed. The air smelled like gasoline and cut grass. I stood in the doorway and watched my father work on a mower. He didn't know I was watching. He was in his element,

hands moving with a kind of economy I didn't recognize at the time. No wasted motion. Just work.

I never told him this, but standing in that doorway watching him was the first time I was proud of him in a way I could name. Not because of what he did, but because of how he did it. Like it mattered to him. Like he cared about getting it right even when nobody was watching.

One morning, I must have been about eight, I asked him:

"Dad, don't you ever get tired?"

He looked at me and said:

"Every day. But being tired doesn't mean you stop."

That was the closest thing to a philosophy lesson I ever got from him. And I didn't fully understand it until I was a grown man, flat on my back in a hospital bed, trying to find a reason to keep fighting.

I remember one Saturday he was fixing the sink in our bathroom. The pipe under the cabinet had been dripping for weeks. He was on his back, half inside the cabinet, wrench in hand, muttering. I sat in the doorway watching. After a while, he handed me a flashlight and told me to hold it steady.

I held it for what felt like an hour. My arm ached. I wanted to quit. But he kept working, so I kept holding.

When he finished, he stood up, wiped his hands on a rag, and said:

"Next time, you're handing me the tools."

He didn't say "good job." He didn't have to. The fact that he expected me to do it again next time meant I'd done it right.

My mother was the quiet force that held everything together. She kept the house running on a budget that shouldn't have worked. She made sure there was dinner on the table every night — not fancy, but hot. She stretched leftovers into another meal. She patched clothes instead of buying new ones. She made sure we felt loved even when the cupboards were getting thin.

I remember coming home from school one day — must have been sixth grade. I was upset about something, some kid said something, the kind of thing you think matters at that age. I came storming through the back door, ready to unload on whoever would listen.

She was at the kitchen sink, peeling potatoes. She didn't turn around.

She said:

"John, you can't control what other people say. You can only control what you do next."

That was it. No lecture. No long talk. Just a sentence delivered to the window over the sink while potato skins curled into the basin. I stood there for a second, then went to my room. The thing that had been burning in my chest didn't seem so big anymore.

Another lesson I didn't fully appreciate until life beat it into me years later.

My parents weren't wealthy. We weren't poor either, not really. But there wasn't much extra. If I wanted something beyond what they could provide, I worked for it. I mowed lawns up and down the street. I shoveled driveways in the winter. I

collected bottles and turned them in for change — five cents a piece, and I'd walk a mile carrying a bag full of them just to have a dollar in my pocket.

I remember one old guy a few blocks over, Mr. Fletcher, who paid me to rake his leaves every fall. He'd sit on his porch in a lawn chair and watch me work. He didn't say much, but at the end he'd hand me a five-dollar bill folded in half and say:

"You did a good job."

That was the first time I remember feeling proud of work I'd done for someone else. It wasn't the money. It was the fact that he noticed.

Nobody handed me anything, and I wasn't raised to expect it.

If I broke something, I fixed it.

If I made a mistake, I owned it.

If I started something, I finished it.

Simple rules. The kind that sound obvious when you say them out loud. Not exactly a secret formula for success. But when life starts throwing punches — and it will — those simple rules are the ones that keep you standing.

They weren't perfect parents. Nobody is. There were raised voices sometimes. There were nights when money was tight and you could feel the tension in the air like humidity before a storm — that heaviness that sits in the house and makes everyone speak softer, move quieter. But they showed up. Every day. They did what needed to be done, even when they were tired, even when they didn't want to, even when they were probably scared themselves.

That image — both of them, just showing up — stayed with me longer than any lecture ever could.

I carried it into school, into my first jobs, into every relationship that mattered. I didn't always get it right. I made plenty of mistakes. I was stubborn when I should have listened, proud when I should have apologized, and hard-headed in ways that cost me time I can't get back.

But I never forgot where I came from.

And when the hard times came — and they came hard, one after another, like life was testing whether I'd learned anything at all — that foundation is what held.

I couldn't see it back then. I was just a kid living his life. I didn't know that every morning watching my father lace up his boots, every evening watching my mother peel potatoes at the sink, every Saturday holding a flashlight until my arm burned, was building something in me.

Something I'd need.

Something that would have to hold against things a kid could never imagine.

2

Chapter 2: The Early Years

My first job was at a body shop.

I was probably sixteen, maybe seventeen. I didn't know anything about cars, but I knew I wanted to work. The owner was a guy named Frank — old-school, bald, always had a cigarette behind his ear that he never seemed to light. He looked me up and down, took measure of me in about two seconds, and said:

“You ever turn a wrench?”

I said:

“No, sir.”

He said:

“Good. Then I don't have to break any bad habits.”

He put me on cleanup. Sweeping, organizing, hauling out scrap metal, degreasing parts in a tank of solvent that burned your

hands if you left them in too long. The shop smelled like bondo, paint thinner, and years of hard use. There was always a radio playing somewhere — classic rock, low enough to ignore, loud enough to keep you company.

I came home every night with black gunk caked under my fingernails and grease in my hair. My mother made me leave my boots on the porch before I came in the house.

I didn't mind the work. I liked using my hands. I liked that when you finished something, you could see what you'd done. A clean floor. A stacked shelf. A part that was covered in grime when you started and gleaming when you were done. There was dignity in it. Nobody had to tell you if you'd done a good job — you could see it for yourself.

There were other guys working there. Older men who'd been turning wrenches since before I was born. They didn't talk much. They'd communicate in grunts and nods. But they noticed when you worked hard. Every now and then, one of them would toss me a ten-dollar bill at the end of the day and say:

“Don't spend it all in one place.”

That meant more to me than any paycheck.

Frank didn't say much either, but when he did, it counted. One day I was struggling to get a bolt loose — must have been seized from years of rust. I was cursing under my breath, about to give up. He walked over, stood next to me for a second, and said:

“You're fighting it. Stop fighting it. Get some penetrating oil, let it sit, come back. The bolt ain't going anywhere.”

I thought he was talking about the bolt. Later I realized he was talking about everything.

That job taught me something I've carried my whole life: you don't get anywhere by being the smartest guy in the room. You get there by being the one who doesn't quit when it gets hard.

I worked a lot of jobs after that. Construction, framing houses in the summer heat. I remember one site where the temperature hit a hundred and the foreman kept bringing us water whether we asked for it or not, because he knew we wouldn't stop on our own. We were setting trusses that day — swinging them into place, balancing on wall plates, nailing them down before the wind caught them. By noon my gloves were soaked through and my shirt looked like I'd been standing in the rain. But nobody quit, so I didn't either.

Warehouses after that, loading trucks until my back screamed and my knuckles were raw from strapping down freight. I remember one night we had a trailer that needed to be loaded before morning — sixty skids, tight fit, and the forklift broke down two hours in. The supervisor said we could wait for repairs, come back tomorrow. I said:

"Give me a hand truck. I'll get it done."

He looked at me like I was crazy. But I was already dragging the first skid toward the trailer.

I worked until three in the morning, one skid at a time, sweating through my shirt in the middle of December. When I finished, the place was quiet except for the hum of the freezer units. I sat on the loading dock for a minute, just breathing. My hands were blistered. My shoulders felt like they'd been pulled apart and put back wrong.

But the truck was loaded and ready to go. And when the supervisor showed up the next morning, he walked past it, looked inside, and didn't say a word. Just gave me a nod. That was enough.

Delivery driving after that, living out of a van, eating gas-station sandwiches between stops, sleeping in the truck when the drive was too long to turn around. I worked whatever I could find. I didn't care what it was. If someone needed a guy, I was the guy.

I never said no. That was my rule, even when I should have. If a boss asked who could stay late, my hand went up before I thought about it. If a crew needed someone to show up on Saturday, I was there. I measured myself by what I could produce, what I could provide, what I could get done. My word was my bond, and my work was my signature.

Some people called it a work ethic. Maybe it was. But looking back, I think part of it was fear. Plain and simple. I was afraid that if I stopped, even for a minute, I'd fall behind. And once you fall behind, it's hard to catch up. I'd seen guys who took their foot off the gas — they never got it back.

There were good years in there too. Late nights with friends I don't see anymore. Weekends that felt like they'd never end. Cold beer and louder laughter than you'd hear anywhere else. A few of us would pile into somebody's truck and just drive, windows down, nowhere to be, nothing to prove. I remember sitting on a tailgate one night, looking up at the stars, thinking this was what life was supposed to feel like. No plan. No pressure. Just being alive and young and dumb enough to think it would last forever.

The kind of freedom you only have before life hands you the bills, the responsibilities, the hard choices that narrow your

world down to what really matters.

I felt invincible. I thought I had all the time in the world.

I didn't know I was building habits that would take years to undo. I didn't know that pushing through every wall would eventually push back. I didn't know that the same drive that made me a good worker would one day make it hard to ask for help, hard to slow down, hard to admit I was in over my head.

I look back on those years with a lot of fondness, but I don't romanticize them. I made plenty of bad choices along with the good ones. I burned bridges I shouldn't have. I let pride get in the way more than once. But even the mistakes taught me something.

They were preparation. Every job, every person, every mistake, every night I pushed through when I should have slept — it was all leading somewhere.

I just didn't know where yet. But I'd find out soon enough.

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Chapter 3: Finding Love

The summer I turned twenty-seven, I wasn't looking for anything serious. I was working double shifts at the plant, drinking with the guys on weekends, and telling myself I had everything I needed. I had my independence. I had my truck — a rusted-out Ford F-150 with more miles on it than I wanted to count. I had a roof over my head that I paid for myself. What else did a man need?

Then my buddy Carl started in on me at the shop one Friday. He said:

“You gotta come to this barbecue at my cousin’s place tomorrow. There’s gonna be food, beer, and I heard his wife’s got a friend who just moved back to town.”

I wiped the grease off my hands and told him I wasn't interested in being set up. Carl laughed and said:

“Nobody’s setting you up, John. I’m just saying there’ll be food. You like food.”

I did like food. So I went.

The barbecue was at a house on the outskirts of town, a little brick ranch with a chain-link fence and a grill the size of a small car. There were maybe thirty people there. Guys from Carl's family, their wives, kids running around the yard, music playing from a boombox on the porch. I grabbed a beer and a paper plate and found a spot in the shade.

That's where I saw her for the first time.

She was standing by the grill, talking to Carl's cousin's wife, holding a plastic cup of iced tea. She wasn't trying to be the center of attention. She wasn't dressed to impress — just jeans and a plain white T-shirt. She was laughing at something, her head tilted back, completely comfortable in her own skin. I'd seen plenty of women try too hard. Genie wasn't trying at all. That's what got me.

I walked over. Introduced myself. She shook my hand — firm grip, looked me right in the eye — and said:

"You're John. Carl's told me about you."

I asked her what Carl had said, expecting the usual friendly nonsense. She smiled and said:

"He said you're stubborn, hard-headed, and you work too much."

I laughed. That sounded about right. I said:

"Sounds about right. What else did he say?"

She looked me right in the eye and said:

“He said you’re a good man. I’m still deciding if I believe him.”

That stopped me. Most women I’d met would have smiled and nodded and told me what they thought I wanted to hear. Genie looked at me like she was taking my measure, like she wasn’t going to be impressed until I gave her a reason to be. I liked that. I didn’t know it at the time, but I needed that.

We talked for the rest of the afternoon. About nothing and everything. She told me she’d just come back from spending two years taking care of her mother, who had been sick. She didn’t say it like she was looking for sympathy. She said it like it was a fact — she’d done what needed to be done and now she was moving on. That impressed me more than anything. I’d known plenty of people who talked about what they were going to do. Genie talked about what she’d already done.

I asked her if she wanted to get dinner sometime. She said:

“I might. Ask me again tomorrow.”

So I did. I called her the next day from a payphone outside the plant, still smelling like grease and sweat. She answered on the third ring and I said:

“This is John. From the barbecue. I’m asking you to dinner.”

She laughed and said:

“You don’t waste time, do you?”

I said:

“Never saw the point.”

Our first date was at a little Italian place on the south side of town. Nothing fancy. Red-and-white checkered tablecloths, candles in Chianti bottles, a jukebox that played Sinatra and Dean Martin. I was nervous, which surprised me. I wasn't the nervous type. But there was something about her that made me want to get it right.

We ordered spaghetti and split a bottle of wine. She told me about growing up in a house with three brothers and a father who worked on the railroad. She told me about the first time she fell in love and how it fell apart. She told me she wanted kids someday, but she wasn't in a hurry. She said she wanted to build something first — something solid — so that when the kids came, they'd have a foundation to stand on.

I listened more than I talked. That wasn't like me either. But Genie had a way of drawing things out of you without demanding them. By the end of the night, I'd told her things I hadn't told anyone. About my own father, and the way he worked himself into an early grave. About the fear I carried that I'd end up the same way. About the nights I lay awake wondering if there was more to life than shifts and weekends and waiting for something to happen.

She reached across the table and put her hand on mine. She said:

“You don't have to have it all figured out tonight, John. You've got time.”

Nobody had ever said that to me before. Everybody always wanted me to be further along — to have more, to be more. Genie looked at me and saw someone who was still becoming, and she was okay with that.

We saw each other every day after that. I'd pick her up after work and we'd go for drives. We'd sit on the hood of my truck and watch the sunset. We'd talk about our families, our fears, the things we hoped for but were afraid to say out loud. I fell in love with her slowly and then all at once. One day I looked at her and realized I couldn't imagine my life without her in it. That was the day I knew.

I didn't propose in any dramatic way. There was no fancy restaurant, no ring in a champagne glass. I just asked her one night on my porch, sitting in an old rocking chair that creaked every time I moved. I said:

"Genie, I'm not good with words. But I know what I feel. And what I feel is that I want to spend the rest of my life with you. I don't have much to offer. I've got a job, a truck, and this house I'm still paying off. But what I have, I'd give to you. All of it."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she said:

"That's the most honest thing anyone's ever said to me. Yes."

We got married at the courthouse three weeks later. Her brothers came. Carl was my best man. My mother cried. My father shook my hand and said:

“She’s a good one, son. Don’t mess it up.”

I promised him I wouldn’t.

The first few years weren’t easy. We had money problems. We had arguments about where to live, how to spend, when to start a family. I was still stubborn and hard-headed. Genie was patient, but she wasn’t a pushover. She’d stand her ground when she had to. We had one fight where I walked out and drove around for two hours, tires squealing around corners, radio blasting, feeling sorry for myself. When I came back, she was sitting at the kitchen table with a cup of coffee, waiting. She said:

“You done?”

I said I was. She said:

“Good. Now sit down and talk to me.”

That was Genie. She never let me run. She never let me hide. She made me face the things I didn’t want to face, and she did it without shame or blame. She did it because she loved me.

When our first daughter was born, I wasn’t ready. I don’t think any man is, no matter how much they prepare. I held her in my arms — this tiny, wrinkled, screaming bundle of life — and I felt something shift in my chest. Suddenly I wasn’t the most important person in my own world anymore. This little girl was. I looked at Genie, exhausted and glowing, and I said:

“She’s perfect.”

Genie smiled and said:

“Of course she is. She’s got my genes.”

I laughed. But I also cried. I didn’t want her to see it, so I turned away and pretended to be looking out the window. But Genie saw. Genie always saw.

Our second daughter came two years later. Same hospital, same room, same feeling of terrified wonder. I held her and thought: I have two of them now. Two little people who depend on me. Two reasons to get up in the morning. Two reasons to be better than I was.

The years that followed were a blur of diapers and doctor’s appointments and school plays and sleepless nights. Genie handled most of it. She was the one who remembered the pediatrician appointments. She was the one who packed the lunches and signed the permission slips and stayed up late sewing Halloween costumes. I was the one working the overtime shifts, coming home exhausted, falling asleep on the couch. I told myself I was providing for them. And I was. But Genie was providing something I couldn’t: presence.

She’d sit with our girls for hours, reading them stories, answering their questions, listening to their tales about school and friends and the small dramas that filled their world. She was patient in ways I wasn’t. She was soft when I was hard. When I’d raise my voice, she’d lower hers. When I wanted to punish, she wanted to teach. We balanced each other out.

One particular night has stayed with me. I’d had a rough day at work — a machine broke down, a foreman chewed me out, I came home with my jaw tight and my shoulders aching. The girls were laughing too loud, running through the living room,

and I snapped. I yelled at them to settle down. They went quiet. I saw their faces fall, and I felt like the biggest piece of garbage in the world.

Later that night, after I'd apologized and put them to bed, Genie came and sat next to me on the couch. She was tired — I could see it in her eyes. But she was still there. Still beside me. I said:

"I don't know why you put up with me."

She leaned her head on my shoulder and said:

"Because I know who you are, John. Even when you forget."

In that moment, sitting in our cramped little living room with the TV playing softly in the background and the sound of our daughters breathing through the thin walls, I felt something I'd never felt before. Contentment. Not happiness that comes and goes. Something deeper. Something that stays.

I didn't know, sitting there, what was coming for us. I didn't know that my body would betray me. I didn't know that I'd lose my way so completely that I wouldn't recognize myself. I didn't know that the storms ahead would test everything we'd built.

But I knew one thing: Genie would be there. And my daughters would be there. And as long as I had them, I had something worth fighting for.

4

Chapter 4: First Blow

It started with a cough. Just a cough. Nothing that would make any man stop and think twice. I'd been working twelve-hour shifts at the plant, breathing in air that wasn't exactly clean, sleeping four or five hours a night if I was lucky. A cough was part of the deal.

But the cough didn't go away. It hung around for weeks, then months. I'd hack into my sleeve on the assembly line and tell myself it was allergies, or the change of seasons, or that Chinese food I ate too late. I wasn't worried. I was never the worrying type.

Then the fatigue hit. Not the usual tired after a long shift. Something deeper. Something that felt like my bones were made of lead. I'd wake up after eight hours of sleep feeling like I hadn't closed my eyes. I'd drag myself through the day, counting the hours until I could go home and collapse. My foreman noticed. He pulled me aside one afternoon and said:

"Thompson, you look like hell. You need to see a doctor."

I told him I was fine. He said:

“I didn’t ask if you were fine. I said you need to see a doctor. Take tomorrow off. That’s an order.”

I didn’t argue. Partly because he was my boss, and partly because some part of me knew he was right.

The doctor’s office smelled like antiseptic and paper. I sat in the waiting room flipping through a *Sports Illustrated* from two years ago, trying to ignore the feeling that something was wrong. When they called my name, I followed the nurse down a long hallway and into a small room with a paper-covered table and a poster about blood pressure on the wall.

The doctor was a thin man with wire-rimmed glasses and a calm voice that made me nervous. Calm voices in doctor’s offices never meant good news. He asked me questions, took some blood, listened to my chest, and told me he’d call with the results.

I didn’t think much of it. I went home, ate dinner, watched TV, fell asleep on the couch.

Three days later, the phone rang. It was the doctor’s office. They asked me to come in.

I knew before I walked through the door. You can tell from the way the receptionist looks at you when you sign in. You can tell from the way the nurse avoids eye contact. You can tell from the fact that they didn’t want to tell me over the phone.

The doctor sat me down in his office, not the exam room. That was the first clue. He had a folder in front of him, and he opened it slowly, like he was giving me time to prepare. He said:

“John, your test results came back. There are some things

we need to talk about.”

He used words I didn't want to hear. Words like *malignancy* and *aggressive* and *immediate treatment*. I sat there and nodded, but the words weren't really landing. They were bouncing off some wall I'd put up in my head. I heard them, but I didn't absorb them. Not yet.

He asked me if I had any questions. I asked:

“Am I going to die?”

He paused. Then he said:

“I can't promise you you won't. But I can promise you we're going to do everything we can.”

That wasn't the answer I wanted. But it was the honest one.

I walked out of that office in a daze. I remember standing in the parking lot, staring at my truck, not knowing what to do next. The sun was shining. People were going about their day. The world was still turning. But my world had just stopped.

I don't remember the drive home. I don't remember parking the truck. I remember walking through the front door and seeing Genie in the kitchen, stirring something on the stove. She looked up at me and I must have had something on my face, because she put the spoon down and said:

“John? What happened?”

I couldn't say it. I opened my mouth and nothing came out. She walked over and took my hands and said:

"Tell me."

So I did. I told her everything the doctor had said. I told her the words I didn't want to say out loud. And when I was done, she didn't cry. She didn't fall apart. She just held me and said:

"Okay. Then we fight it."

That was it. No panic. No drama. No asking why us or why now. She just said *we fight it*, and she meant it. And in that moment, I loved her more than I had ever loved anything in my life.

The treatments started two weeks later. They were brutal in ways I couldn't have imagined. The chemicals they pumped into my body made me sick in ways I didn't know a person could be sick. I vomited until there was nothing left. I lost my hair in clumps. I lost weight I couldn't afford to lose. I'd lie in bed and stare at the ceiling and wonder if this was what dying felt like.

Genie was there every day. She'd hold a cool cloth to my forehead. She'd sit beside me and read magazines out loud, even when I was too weak to respond. She'd make me eat when I didn't want to. She'd force me to get up and walk when every part of my body screamed to stay still.

My parents came when they could. My mother would sit and hold my hand and not say much. My father would stand in the corner with his arms crossed, looking like he wanted to trade places with me. He said:

"I'd take this from you if I could, son."

I said:

"I know you would, Dad."

Friends called and visited and brought food and offered help. I was surrounded by people who wanted to see me make it through. And I was grateful for every single one of them. But there was a part of the fight that was mine alone. Nobody could sit in that hospital bed for me. Nobody could get sick for me. Nobody could decide, every single morning, whether to keep going or to give up.

There were mornings I wanted to give up. I won't pretend otherwise. I'd wake up and the nausea would hit before I even opened my eyes. I'd think about what I looked like now — thin, bald, weak. I'd think about Genie and the girls and wonder if they'd be better off without me dragging them through this. I'd think about how easy it would be to just close my eyes and stop fighting.

But then I'd hear the girls in the other room, laughing about something, fighting over a toy, living their lives the way children do. And I'd think: I can't leave them. I can't let them grow up without a father. I can't let them remember me as the man who gave up.

So I'd get up. I'd force myself to eat. I'd take the next round of poison they called medicine. I'd do the work.

One night, after a particularly rough treatment, I was lying in bed and Genie was sitting beside me. I asked her:

"Are you scared?"

She didn't pretend. She said:

"Every day."

I said:

"I'm sorry."

She said:

"Don't be sorry. Just keep fighting."

And I did.

The recovery was slow. Measured in inches, not miles. I gained back a little weight. My hair grew back, thin and gray in places it hadn't been before. I started walking farther, then running, then lifting things I couldn't have lifted a month earlier. Every small victory felt like a miracle. Every good day was a gift.

About six months after the diagnosis, I went back to work. The guys at the plant clapped me on the back and told me I looked good. Carl brought a cake. My foreman shook my hand and said:

"Glad to have you back, Thompson."

I was glad to be back. But something had changed in me. I looked at the plant floor and saw it differently now — not just a place to earn a paycheck, but a place I'd been given the chance to see again.

I thought that was the end of it. I thought I'd been through the worst and life would cut me a break. I went to bed every night thinking the hard part was over. I looked at Genie and the girls and felt like we'd made it through the fire.

I didn't know that the fire was just the beginning. I didn't know that surviving the illness would lead me into a different

kind of darkness. I didn't know that the hardest test was still waiting for me.

But that's the thing about life. You never know what's coming next. You just have to be ready to face it when it arrives.

5

Chapter 5: Losing My Way

After the illness, I thought I was invincible again.

I wasn't.

The doctors told me I was in remission. The guys at work threw me a party. Genie cried when she heard the news. The girls made me a card with crayon drawings and crooked letters that spelled out *We love you Daddy*. Everything looked like it was supposed to be fine.

But I didn't feel fine.

The thing nobody tells you about surviving something terrible is that the scars don't all show. They cut the tumor out of my body, but they couldn't cut the fear out of my head. It stayed there, curled up like a snake, waiting. It talked to me in the quiet moments. It told me I was weak. That it could come back at any time. That I was living on borrowed time and the bank was going to call in the debt.

I didn't know how to handle those voices. So I drowned them out.

It started small. A beer after work. Then two. Then a six-pack. I told myself I deserved it. I'd been through hell. I'd earned the

right to let loose a little. And for a while, it worked. The beer quieted the voices. It let me sleep without staring at the ceiling. It let me laugh without the fear creeping in.

But it didn't stop at beer.

I don't even remember who gave me the first pill. Some guy at the plant, probably. A little white tablet he said would take the edge off. I said okay and swallowed it and waited. When it hit, I understood. The noise in my head didn't just quiet down — it disappeared. For a few hours, I felt like the old John. The John before the diagnosis. The John who didn't lie awake wondering if every ache and pain was the cancer coming back.

I chased that feeling.

It didn't take long for the habit to dig its claws in. I started keeping pills in my truck, in my toolbox, in the back of my sock drawer. I'd pop one before work, during lunch, after dinner. I told myself I had it under control. I told myself I could stop anytime. I told everyone who asked that I was fine.

I wasn't fine.

Genie noticed first. She always noticed. She'd look at me across the dinner table and I'd see her studying me, trying to figure out what was different. I'd make sure to meet her eyes and smile, but she wasn't buying it. One night she said:

"John, you seem different lately. Distant. Are you okay?"

I said:

"I'm fine. Just tired."

She said:

“You’re always tired lately.”

I said:

“I work twelve hours a day. I’m supposed to be tired.”

She let it drop. But I could see she wasn’t convinced.

The thing about addiction is that it makes you an expert liar. You learn how to hide things. You learn how to read people’s faces and tell them exactly what they want to hear. You learn how to keep the people who love you at arm’s length, because if they get too close, they’ll see what you don’t want them to see.

I’d come home and kiss Genie on the cheek and go straight to the bathroom and lock the door. I’d take a pill, wash it down, look at myself in the mirror, and tell myself I deserved this. I’d been through so much. I just needed something to take the edge off. There was nothing wrong with that.

But there was something wrong. I knew it. And every night I’d lie in bed and promise myself I’d stop tomorrow. And every morning I’d wake up and reach for the bottle beside my bed.

One night, Genie found the pills.

I had left my jacket draped over a chair in the kitchen. She went to hang it up and something fell out of the pocket. A little orange bottle with no label. She opened it and found the pills and when I walked in, she was standing there holding them.

She said:

“What are these?”

I said:

“Nothing. Just something for my back.”

She said:

“Your back doesn’t hurt, John. I’ve never heard you complain about your back.”

I said:

“Well it does. Okay?”

I could hear the lie in my own voice. It was thin and obvious and it embarrassed me. But I couldn’t stop. I couldn’t tell her the truth. I couldn’t admit what I’d become.

She said:

“John, I’m not stupid. I know something’s wrong. Please talk to me.”

I didn’t talk to her. I got angry. I said things I shouldn’t have said. I told her to mind her own business. I told her she didn’t understand. I grabbed the bottle out of her hand and walked out of the house.

I drove around for hours that night. I ended up at a bar I’d never been to before, a place on the edge of town where nobody knew my name. I sat at the counter and drank whiskey until my thoughts went blurry. I thought about Genie’s face when she’d found those pills. I thought about what I’d said to her. I thought about what a worthless piece of garbage I was.

But I didn’t go home. I stayed until the bartender told me I’d had enough. I stumbled out to my truck and slept in the

front seat. When I woke up, the sun was coming up and I was shivering and I felt like I'd been hit by a train.

I went home. Genie was sitting at the kitchen table, still in her robe, a cup of coffee in front of her. The coffee was cold. She'd been sitting there all night. She looked at me and didn't say anything. That was worse than if she'd screamed.

I said:

"I'm sorry."

She looked at me for a long time. Then she said:

"I know you are. But sorry isn't enough this time."

I hit bottom a few weeks later. I don't mean that as a metaphor. I mean there was a moment where I looked at myself and didn't know who I was anymore. I was standing in the bathroom, shaking, sweating, needing a fix. I looked in the mirror and saw a stranger. Hollow eyes. Gray skin. A man I didn't recognize.

I thought about my daughters. I thought about them growing up and remembering me like this. I thought about them telling their own children about their father — the man who couldn't stop. The man who chose pills over his family.

I sat down on the bathroom floor and I cried. I hadn't cried since I was a kid. I sat there and sobbed like a child, and I prayed. I hadn't prayed in years. I said:

"God, if you're real, help me. I can't do this alone."

Nothing happened. No voice from heaven. No sudden clarity. But something shifted. Some small part of me decided that I

was done. Not because I wanted to be. Because I had run out of other options.

I walked out of the bathroom and found Genie. I told her everything. The pills. The lies. The mornings I couldn't get out of bed without something in my system. The nights I prayed I wouldn't wake up. I told her the truth, every ugly piece of it.

She didn't say much. She listened. When I was done, she said:

"I'll call a program in the morning."

I said:

"I don't know if I can do it."

She said:

"That's fine. You don't have to know. You just have to try."

Getting clean was harder than the cancer treatments. At least with the cancer, there was a plan. A schedule. A team of doctors telling me what to do and when to do it. With addiction, there was just me and the empty space where the drugs used to be. The cravings hit like waves. I'd be fine for an hour, then I'd be drowning. Genie would hold me and tell me to breathe.

I went to meetings. I sat in folding chairs and listened to other people talk about their own battles. I heard stories that sounded like mine. I felt less alone. I started to believe that maybe I could make it through.

But I also learned something important about myself. I learned that I had been running from the fear instead of facing

it. The cancer had scared me in a way I didn't want to admit. I thought I could drink and drug my way past it. But you can't outrun fear. It will always catch up.

The only way out was through.

I've been clean for years now. But I still think about those days sometimes. I think about the man I used to be — the one who lied and stole and hurt the people he loved. I don't pretend that man doesn't exist. He's part of me. But he's not who I am anymore.

I got clean because I had to. Not because I wanted to. Not because I was ready. Because I had run out of other options. And sometimes that's what it takes. Sometimes you have to lose everything before you can start to find yourself again.

That was the hardest thing I ever did.

Until the next thing.

6

Chapter 6: Carrying On

I've lost people.

That's a sentence that sounds simple but isn't. When you lose someone you love, it's not like losing your keys. You don't find them later under the couch. They're just gone. And the world keeps spinning like nothing happened.

The first loss that really broke me open was my father.

He'd been sick for a while. Not the dramatic kind of sick that lands you in the hospital with tubes and machines. The slow kind. The kind that eats away at a man piece by piece until there's nothing left. He'd worked his whole life — railroad man, hands calloused and back bent — and his body had finally had enough.

I got the call at work. My mother's voice on the other end, shaky but controlled. She said:

"John, you need to come home. Your father's taken a turn."

I dropped everything. I drove two hours to the old house where

I grew up, speeding the whole way, praying under my breath. When I got there, my father was in the bed he'd shared with my mother for forty-three years. He was thin. So thin. The cancer had eaten him from the inside out, and what was left was a skeleton wrapped in papery skin.

I sat beside him and held his hand. He was awake, barely. His eyes found mine and he tried to smile. He said:

"You came."

I said:

"Of course I came, Dad."

He squeezed my hand. His grip was weak, nothing like the hands that had taught me how to throw a baseball, how to change a tire, how to be a man. He said:

"Take care of your mother. She's going to need you."

I said:

"I will."

He closed his eyes and I thought he was gone. But he opened them again and looked at me and said:

"You did good, son. You did real good."

Those were the last words he ever said to me. He died three hours later, with my mother on one side and me on the other. The

room went quiet. The machine that had been beeping stopped beeping. And my mother let out a sound I'd never heard before — a sound that came from somewhere deeper than crying.

I didn't cry at first. I couldn't. I sat in that room and stared at my father's face and waited for something to hit me. But nothing came. I was hollow.

The funeral was a blur. I shook hands with people I hadn't seen in years. I accepted hugs from cousins I barely recognized. I said the right things — *thank you for coming, he was a good man, he's in a better place* — but I didn't feel any of them. I was going through the motions. My body was there, but the rest of me was somewhere else, floating above the crowd, watching the scene play out like it was a movie about someone else.

The grief didn't hit me until three weeks later.

I was at the grocery store. Standing in the cereal aisle, trying to decide between two brands. And suddenly I couldn't breathe. The fluorescent lights were too bright. The colors on the boxes were too loud. I dropped my basket and walked out of the store. I stood in the parking lot and I wept. Right there, in the middle of the afternoon, with strangers walking past me pushing their carts.

That's the thing about grief. It doesn't follow a schedule. It doesn't care if you have things to do. It hits you in the middle of the grocery store, or while you're driving, or when you see something that reminds you of them and suddenly you can't breathe.

I learned that you don't get over it. You get through it. There's a difference. Getting over it means it stops hurting. Getting through it means you learn to carry the hurt with you without letting it stop you.

I carried a lot after my father died. I carried the memory of

his hand in mine, papery and weak. I carried the sound of my mother's grief. I carried the words he'd said to me — *you did good* — and I held them close, because I knew they were the last gift he'd ever give me.

A few years later, I lost my mother. That was different. My mother had been the constant in my life, the one who wrote letters and remembered birthdays and kept the family together. When my father died, she'd been strong. But after he was gone, something in her started to fade. She didn't get sick — not with anything you could name. She just got tired. She'd lived fifty years with a man she loved, and without him, the color drained out of the world for her.

I visited her every weekend. We'd sit in her living room and drink coffee and talk about the old days. She'd tell me stories about my father that I'd never heard before — how he'd proposed to her on a park bench, how he'd held her hand through three labors, how he still called her beautiful even after forty years.

One weekend she looked at me and said:

"I miss him, John. Every day."

I said:

"I know, Mom."

She said:

"It gets easier, doesn't it?"

I didn't know how to answer that. The truth was that it got

different. Not easier. But I didn't say that. I just nodded and held her hand.

She died in her sleep six months later. Peaceful. Quiet. The way she'd wanted to go. When I got the call, I didn't cry. I sat in my truck for a long time, staring at nothing. Then I drove home and told Genie and let her hold me.

Losing my parents taught me something I couldn't have learned any other way. It taught me that time is short. It taught me that the people you love won't be here forever. It taught me to say the things that matter while you still can.

I started telling Genie I loved her more often. Not just at night before bed. In the middle of the day, for no reason. I'd call her from work and say:

"Just calling to say I love you."

She'd laugh and say:

"Is everything okay?"

I'd say:

"Everything's fine. I just wanted to say it."

I started calling my daughters just to hear their voices. I'd ask them about their day, about their friends, about the small things that filled their lives. I listened more than I talked. I paid attention to the moments that most people rush through.

I remember one afternoon with my oldest daughter. She was sixteen. We were sitting on the porch, watching the rain. Neither of us was talking. Just sitting. After a while, she said:

"Dad, are you okay?"

I said:

"Yeah, honey. I'm okay."

She said:

"You seem different lately."

I thought about how to answer. Then I said:

"I've been thinking about Grandpa a lot."

She nodded. She knew what I meant. She'd seen what losing him did to me. She said:

"I miss him too."

We sat there a little longer. Then she leaned her head against my shoulder. It was a small thing. But it meant everything.

Loss took people from me. It took my father and my mother and friends I'd known my whole life. But it also gave me something I didn't expect: the determination to not waste the time I have left.

I think about my father's last words to me. *You did good.* I want to earn those words. I want to be able to look back at the end of my life and know that I did good. That I loved the people who mattered. That I showed up when it counted. That I didn't let the fear of losing people stop me from loving them with everything I had.

Grief doesn't ever really leave. It sits in a corner of your heart and waits. But over time, you learn to make room for it. You learn to carry it the way you'd carry a wounded child — carefully, gently, without letting it weigh you down so much that you can't move forward.

I'm still carrying it. I'll probably carry it for the rest of my life. But I've learned something important: the carrying doesn't stop you from living. It just reminds you why living matters. And as long as I have people to love, I'll keep showing up. I'll keep calling just to hear their voices. I'll keep saying the things that matter while I still can.

Because that's what my father would have wanted. And that's what my mother would have wanted. And that's what I want my daughters to remember about me when I'm gone.

7

Chapter 7: The Heart Attack

It happened when I least expected it.

Doesn't it always?

I was at the plant, doing what I always did. Pushing through. Ignoring the signs. There was pressure in my chest, but I told myself it was nothing. Indigestion. Stress. Lack of sleep. I'd had worse. I'd survived cancer. I'd survived addiction. A little chest discomfort wasn't going to stop me.

But the discomfort didn't stop. It spread. From my chest up into my jaw, down my left arm. I remember standing on the assembly line, clutching the railing, trying to breathe. The guy next to me, a kid named Danny, asked:

"You okay, Thompson?"

I said:

"Fine. Just need a minute."

I didn't have a minute. The pain got worse. It felt like someone

was sitting on my chest, like an elephant had decided to make itself comfortable. I broke out in a cold sweat. The world started to go gray around the edges.

Danny grabbed my arm and said:

“You’re not fine. Sit down.”

I didn’t argue. I couldn’t. I slid down onto the concrete floor and leaned my back against the machine. The gray was closing in. I heard Danny yelling for someone to call 911. I heard footsteps, voices, the distant sound of a phone ringing. All of it sounded like it was coming from the end of a long tunnel.

Then I heard nothing.

The next thing I remember is waking up in the hospital. White ceiling. Fluorescent lights. The smell of antiseptic and the steady beep of machines. I blinked and tried to sit up, but a hand pushed me back down. Genie’s hand.

She was sitting beside me. Her eyes were red. She’d been crying. She said:

“Don’t move. Just rest.”

I said:

“What happened?”

She said:

“You had a heart attack, John. A bad one.”

I lay there and let that sink in. A heart attack. Of all the things

I'd survived — the cancer, the addiction, the grief — my own heart had tried to kill me. I almost laughed. It was either laugh or cry, and I didn't have the energy for either.

The doctor came in later. A young woman with a serious face and a gentle voice. She sat down beside my bed and explained what had happened. Blocked artery. The kind they call the widow-maker. If I'd gotten to the hospital ten minutes later, she said, I probably wouldn't be here.

Ten minutes.

I thought about all the things that could have gone differently. What if Danny hadn't been working next to me? What if I'd ignored the pain and gone to the bathroom like I'd been planning? What if I'd driven myself home instead of waiting for the ambulance? The thought made me cold.

The doctor said:

"You're going to need to make some changes."

I said:

"What kind of changes?"

She said:

"The kind you're not going to like."

She was right. I didn't like them. She told me I needed to change my diet. No more red meat three times a week. No more fried food. No more salt by the handful. She told me I needed to exercise — not the kind of exercise I did at work, but real exercise, measured and consistent. She told me I needed to

manage my stress, which was a polite way of saying I needed to stop carrying the weight of the world on my shoulders.

I listened to all of it and nodded. But inside, I was fighting it. This wasn't who I was. I was the guy who ate what he wanted and worked until he dropped and handled stress by ignoring it. The idea of changing all of that felt like losing a part of myself.

But the alternative was dying. And I wasn't ready to die.

The recovery was slow. Harder than I expected. They had me in cardiac rehab three times a week, hooked up to monitors, walking on a treadmill at a pace that would have bored a turtle. I'd look at the machines and think: I used to carry hundred-pound bags of concrete. I used to work twelve-hour shifts without sitting down. Now I'm walking on a treadmill and calling it progress.

But it was progress. I had to learn to measure success differently. Not by how much I could lift or how fast I could move, but by the small victories. Walking for five minutes without getting winded. Climbing a flight of stairs without stopping. Getting my blood pressure under 140.

Genie was with me every step of the way. She changed her diet too, even though she didn't have to. She'd cook meals that fit the new plan and eat them with me, never complaining. She walked with me when I needed to walk. She sat with me when I needed to rest. She told me I was doing good, even on the days when I felt like I was failing.

One night, about a month after the attack, I was lying in bed, staring at the ceiling. Genie was beside me, almost asleep. I said:

"I keep thinking about what the doctor said. About the ten minutes."

She said:

“Don’t think about that. You’re here. That’s what matters.”

I said:

“But what if I hadn’t— ”

She cut me off. She rolled over and looked at me and said:

“John, you didn’t. That’s the point. You’re still here. Don’t waste the time you’ve been given worrying about the time you almost didn’t have.”

I knew she was right. But the fear didn’t go away. It sat in my chest like a stone. I’d feel every heartbeat and wonder if it was going to be the last one. I’d wake up in the middle of the night with my heart pounding, convinced it was happening again. The fear was its own kind of prison.

One day at rehab, I saw an old man on the treadmill next to mine. He was probably eighty, thin as a rail, with a scar running down the middle of his chest from bypass surgery. He was moving at a pace that was barely a crawl, but his eyes were focused and his jaw was set. I asked him how long he’d been coming. He said three years. I asked him if it got easier. He smiled and said:

“No. But you get tougher.”

I thought about that a lot. *No, but you get tougher.* That was the

truth of it. The heart attack had changed me. It had cracked something open. But the cracks were starting to heal, and the healed places were stronger than before.

I started to make peace with the new version of myself. The version who ate vegetables and took walks and didn't let the small things eat him alive. The version who stopped at the speed limit and didn't feel the need to be first everywhere he went. The version who understood that rest wasn't weakness — it was survival.

I thought about all the things I'd survived. The cancer. The addiction. The grief. The heart attack. I started to see a pattern I hadn't seen before. Life was trying to take me out. And every time, I was choosing to stay. That wasn't weakness. That was stubbornness. And if there was one thing I had, it was stubbornness.

I started writing this book about six months after the heart attack. I didn't know if anyone would ever read it. I didn't know if I had anything worth saying. But I needed to leave something behind. Something that proved I was here. Something that my daughters could hold in their hands and say: *This was my father. This was his life.*

The old John couldn't keep going the way he had been. That version of me was done. And it took a while to accept that. But I did. Because I had a choice: adapt or die. And I wasn't ready to die.

I still had things to do. People to love. A story to finish writing.

I think about my father sometimes, in those last moments. The look in his eyes when he told me I'd done good. I want to earn that. Not just for him, but for myself. I want to look back at the end of my life and know that I didn't give up. That I kept fighting, even when the fight got hard. That I loved the people

who mattered and told them so.

The heart attack didn't kill me. It came close, but close doesn't count. What it did was remind me that every day is borrowed time. Every beat of my heart is a gift I don't deserve and can't repay.

But I can spend it well. I can use it to love my wife, to be there for my daughters, to tell the truth about who I was and what I learned. I can use it to finish this story.

And that's exactly what I intend to do.

8

Chapter 8: Cancer

I was sitting in the exam room on a cold Tuesday morning in November. The kind of morning where the sky is gray and the air has that bite that tells you winter is coming. I'd been having some issues for a few weeks. Nothing I wanted to admit was serious. Just tired. Losing weight without trying. A cough that wouldn't quit. I figured it was stress. I figured it was age. I figured it was everything else I'd already been through, just piling up like junk mail.

The doctor came in. Dr. Morrison. Good man. Straight shooter. The kind of doctor who looks you in the eye when he talks to you, which is the first sign that what he's about to say is not going to be easy to hear. He sat down on the little rolling stool, held a file folder in his hands, and looked at me for a second without saying anything. Then he said:

"John, the biopsy came back. It's cancer."

And the room got quiet.

Not the kind of quiet where you could hear a pin drop. The kind of quiet where sound itself gets up and leaves the building. I could see his mouth moving, telling me more. Something

about the type. Something about the stage. Something about treatment options. But the words were coming through like a radio station with bad reception. Every few syllables broke through — “lung” — “aggressive” — “we caught it” — and then static again.

I remember thinking: Again? Really? How much more am I supposed to take?

I didn't say it out loud. I just nodded. Shook his hand. Thanked him, because that's what you do. Then I walked out to the waiting room where Genie was sitting, and she took one look at my face and she knew. She didn't ask. She just stood up, walked over, and put her arms around me. We stood there for a long time. People walking past us. Nurses at the desk. Someone calling a name over the intercom. And we just stood there holding each other.

The treatments started two weeks later.

Radiation therapy. Before I started, I didn't really know what to expect. Most people hear the word radiation and picture something dramatic. I know I did. I imagined I'd feel something while it was happening, like I'd know the exact moment the machine was doing its work. The reality was different.

Every weekday for four weeks I reported to the cancer center. The routine became familiar. Check in. Wait my turn. Walk back when they called my name. The technicians were professional and reassuring. They explained what they were doing, answered my questions, and made sure I was positioned exactly the same way every single time. Precision mattered. They weren't just treating cancer; they were trying to protect as much healthy tissue as they could.

Once everything was lined up, they would leave the room while the machine did its work. That part always felt strange. You're

lying there by yourself, perfectly still, knowing the treatment has started even though you can't actually feel it. No burning. No pain while the machine was running. Just the quiet hum of the equipment and the knowledge that every treatment was another step in the fight.

At first I thought, "Maybe this won't be as bad as I expected." Then the days started adding up.

Radiation has a way of wearing you down little by little. It isn't like flipping a switch. The fatigue creeps in. Every day it takes just a little more out of you than the day before. I'd wake up tired. I'd spend the day tired. Rest helped, but it never seemed to completely refill the tank.

My throat became sore. Swallowing wasn't as easy as it used to be. Eating became more of a chore than something I enjoyed. Some days I had very little appetite at all. There were meals where I'd take a few bites and decide that was enough.

I remember standing in front of the bathroom mirror one morning, looking at myself and not quite recognizing the man looking back. He was thinner. Paler. His eyes carried a tiredness that sleep couldn't fix. He looked like someone who had been fighting a battle every single day, and in many ways, that's exactly what he was doing.

Genie came to every appointment. Every single one. She sat beside me in the waiting room, reading her book or simply talking with me until they called my name. She drove when I didn't feel like driving. She kept me company on the ride home. She never once complained about the hours we spent going back and forth to the hospital. Not once.

One afternoon, after a particularly rough treatment, I looked at her and said:

"I don't know if I can keep doing this."

She looked me right in the eye and said:

“You can. And you will. Because we’re not done yet.”

She didn’t say “you’re not done yet.” She said “we’re not done yet.” And that made all the difference in the world.

My daughters came to visit on weekends. They’d sit with me, watch TV shows I wasn’t really watching, tell me stories about their jobs and their lives. They tried to act normal, like everything was fine, like their dad wasn’t exhausted from weeks of fighting cancer. I tried to act normal too. I cracked jokes. I asked questions. I made sure they knew I was still in there, still fighting, still their old man.

We were all pretending, and we all knew it.

But pretending is better than giving up. Pretending is a form of hope. It’s saying: I’m going to act like this is temporary, because if I act like it’s temporary, maybe it will be.

There was one night—I’ll never forget it—when I was alone in the house. Genie had gone to the pharmacy to pick up a prescription. The house was quiet. I was lying in bed, staring at the ceiling, and I felt the fear wash over me like a wave. Not the surface-level fear you feel when you’re watching a scary movie. The deep fear. The kind that sits in your bones and whispers: What if this doesn’t work? What if this is it?

I started to cry.

I don’t say that lightly. I wasn’t raised in a house where men cried. My father was a good man, but he was from a generation that believed tears were a sign of weakness. I’d carried that with me my whole life, this idea that you push through, you suck it up, you don’t let anyone see you break. But that night, alone in the dark, I broke. I cried for myself. I cried for Genie. I cried for my daughters. I cried for all the years I’d wasted being angry and scared and stubborn when I could have been grateful.

And then I stopped crying.

I wiped my face.

I sat up.

I said out loud, to no one in particular:

“I’m not done.”

I don’t know who I was saying it to. God. The universe. Myself. But saying it made it real. Saying it made it a promise.

The weeks of treatment eventually came to an end, but the waiting didn’t. In some ways, waiting for the results was harder than the treatments themselves. During treatment, at least I was doing something. Once the last radiation session was over, all I could do was wait and hope.

The months that followed were hard. Harder than anything I’d done before, and I’d already done some hard things. There were days when I didn’t have the strength to get out of bed. There were days when eating a single cracker felt like a victory. There were days when hope felt like a luxury I couldn’t afford, like buying a sports car when you can’t pay the rent.

But there were good days too. Days when I had a little more energy than the day before. Days when a friend would call and tell a joke that made me laugh so hard I forgot, for a minute, what I was going through. Days when Genie would crawl into bed next to me and just hold my hand, not saying anything, just being there, and that was enough.

Some time after the treatments were finished, I went in for the scan that would tell us if they had worked. I remember sitting in the waiting room, trying to read a magazine, not reading a single word. Genie was next to me, squeezing my hand so hard I think she left bruises. When Dr. Morrison came out, he had the same look on his face that he’d had that first day. The look that says: I have news.

He sat down and said:

“John, the scan is clear. No evidence of active cancer.”

I didn’t react the way I thought I would. I didn’t cry. I didn’t cheer. I just sat there, letting the words sink in. Clear. No evidence. Active cancer. They were just words. But they were the best words I’d ever heard.

Genie threw her arms around me. I hugged her back. And then I walked out of that hospital, got in the car, and sat there for ten minutes before I could bring myself to start the engine.

I beat cancer. I say that like it’s simple, but it wasn’t. It was four weeks of radiation. It was months of fear, pain, uncertainty, and waiting. It was waking up every day not knowing if the treatments were working. It was trying to find hope when hope felt like a luxury I couldn’t afford. It was leaning on the people who loved me, even when I didn’t feel like I deserved to be loved.

But I beat it.

And I thought: That’s it. I’ve paid my dues. Life is done with me.

I was wrong again.

Chapter 9: The Leg

I don't remember the exact moment they told me they were going to take it.

Maybe I blocked it out. Maybe my brain decided that particular memory wasn't worth keeping, like deleting an old file to free up space. Or maybe nobody had to tell me because I already knew. The leg had been giving me trouble for a while. Pain that started as a dull ache and grew into something sharper. Circulation problems from years of everything I'd put my body through — the drinking, the smoking, the poor diet, the heart attack, the cancer. Your body keeps score. Every bad decision, every night you stayed out too late, every cigarette you swore was the last one — it all goes into the ledger. And eventually, the bill comes due.

My right leg was the bill.

The vascular specialist was a younger guy. Early forties, maybe. Sharp. He didn't waste time with small talk. He sat me down in his office, pulled up the images on his monitor, and pointed at the screen. I could see the problem before he even explained it. The blood flow was almost nonexistent. The tissue

was dying. He said:

“John, we’ve tried everything we can to save the leg. The stents aren’t holding. The bypass didn’t take. If we don’t amputate, the tissue damage will spread, and you’ll be looking at a much bigger problem. Sepsis. Organ failure. We need to take it below the knee.”

I sat there for a minute. The words sat in the air between us like smoke. Below the knee. Below the knee. Below the knee. I kept repeating it in my head, trying to make it feel real. It didn’t feel real. It felt like he was talking about somebody else’s leg. Somebody else’s life.

I asked:

“What are my options?”

He shook his head.

“There aren’t any.”

I appreciated that. No sugarcoating. No false hope. Just the truth, delivered clean and straight. That’s what you want from a surgeon. You want someone who isn’t afraid to tell you the hard thing, because the hard thing is reality, and the sooner you accept reality, the sooner you can start dealing with it.

I drove home that afternoon in a fog. I don’t remember the drive. I don’t remember stopping at any lights or turning any corners. I just remember pulling into the driveway and sitting in the car with the engine running, staring at the garage door, trying to figure out how I was going to tell Genie.

She already knew something was wrong the second I walked in. You can't hide much from a woman you've been married to for decades. She can read your face like a billboard. I sat down at the kitchen table. She sat across from me. I told her:

"They have to take the leg."

She didn't cry. She didn't panic. She just reached across the table, took my hand, and said:

"Then we'll figure it out. Together."

That word again. *We*. I was starting to realize that "we" was the most important word in any marriage.

The surgery was scheduled for a Thursday morning. I spent the night before lying awake, staring at the ceiling, listening to Genie breathe beside me. I thought about all the places that leg had taken me. All the miles I'd walked on it. All the times I'd stood on it when I needed to be steady. It had carried me through a lot, that leg. And I was about to say goodbye to it.

They came to get me at six in the morning. A nurse with a cheerful voice and a wheelchair. I remember thinking how strange it was that they made you sit in a wheelchair to go to the operating room when you were about to lose the ability to walk anyway. Some kind of hospital irony. I kissed Genie goodbye. She said:

"I'll be right here when you wake up."

I believed her.

The surgery took about four hours. I woke up in the recovery

room with a fog in my head and a strange sensation in my right leg that I couldn't quite place. It took me a minute to remember. Then I looked down. The blanket was flat where my leg should have been. There was a bandage. There was pain. There was a strange emptiness that my brain couldn't quite process. It wasn't like looking at something missing. It was like looking at something that was there and not there at the same time. My brain was still sending signals to a leg that didn't exist anymore. Phantom messages to an address that was no longer occupied.

The first time I tried to stand, I fell.

It was two days after the surgery. A physical therapist named Diane came in to help me try to get on my feet. She was a small woman with a big voice and an attitude that said *I'm not going to let you feel sorry for yourself*. I liked her immediately. She helped me swing my legs — leg, I mean — over the side of the bed. She positioned a walker in front of me. She said:

"Alright, John. Let's see what you've got."

I pushed myself up. The world tilted. My balance was gone. I didn't know where my body ended and the space around me began. I took one unsteady hop and felt my hip twist. I went down hard. Diane caught me before I hit the floor, but not before I felt the full weight of my new reality pressing down on me. I sat on the edge of the bed, breathing hard, and said:

"That was pathetic."

Diane said:

"That was the first time. The first time is always pathetic."

You'll get better."

She was right. But "better" took a long time.

The first fitting for the prosthetic was a whole different kind of humbling. The prosthetist was a man named Carlos, a veteran of the business who'd fitted hundreds of amputees. He measured my residual limb, made a plaster cast, and told me to come back in two weeks. When I came back, he handed me a socket made of carbon fiber and a metal pylon with a prosthetic foot attached to the end. It looked like something from a science fiction movie. Lightweight. Modern. Nothing like the wooden peg legs you see in pirate movies. I was grateful for that.

Putting it on for the first time was a nightmare. The socket had to fit tight — tight enough to create a seal, tight enough to hold suction. I pushed my stump into it and felt the pressure immediately. It was like putting your foot into a shoe that was three sizes too small. Carlos adjusted it. Adjusted it again. Handed me a pair of crutches and said:

"Alright. Let's take a walk."

I stood up. The prosthetic clicked against the floor. I took a step. The socket shifted. I took another step. Pain shot up my residual limb. I stopped, closed my eyes, and breathed through it. Carlos said:

"It's going to hurt for a while. That's normal. Your body has to get used to bearing weight in a way it's never done before. But it will get easier."

He was right about that too. But "easier" didn't mean "easy."

The first time I looked in the mirror and saw myself without the leg, I wanted to look away. It was about a week after the surgery. I was home, standing in the bathroom, supporting myself on the sink. I'd taken off the bandage to let the air get to the incision. I looked down. I saw the stump. I saw the stitches. I saw the swelling and the bruising and the strange shape of what was left. I saw a body that looked like it had been through a war. And I guess it had.

I didn't look away.

I forced myself to look. I stared at it for a long time. I told myself: *This is you now. This is your body. This is your life. You don't have to like it, but you have to accept it. Because acceptance is the first step toward moving forward.*

That phrase — “get back up” — it stopped being a motto and started being a job. Every single day, I had to decide that I was going to try again. Every single day, I had to choose between staying on the ground and getting back on my feet. Some days I chose right. Some days I chose wrong. But I never stopped choosing.

I remember the first time I walked from the living room to the kitchen without holding onto anything. It was maybe twenty feet. It took me thirty seconds and I was sweating by the end of it. But I did it. I stood in the kitchen, breathing hard, and I laughed. Genie came in and asked what was funny. I said:

“I just walked across the room. Twenty feet. And it feels like I climbed a mountain.”

She smiled and said:

“Then you climbed a mountain.”

I chose to get back up. Not because I was brave. Not because I was strong. Because the alternative was unacceptable. I had people counting on me. I had a life that wasn't finished. I had a story that wasn't done being written. And I had a wife who used words like "we" when she talked about hard things.

So I got back up. One step at a time. One day at a time. One fall and one recovery at a time.

Chapter 10: The Stump

Nobody warns you what a stump looks like.

After a below-the-knee amputation, the shape of what's left is strange. Muscle, soft tissue, swelling, surgical scars. It doesn't look like a leg anymore. It looks like something else entirely. Something unfinished. Something that's still healing and might not ever look right again.

The first time the bandages came off for good, I was sitting on the edge of the hospital bed. A nurse named Rachel was unwrapping the gauze, layer by layer, talking to me about discharge instructions, trying to keep me distracted. I wasn't distracted. I was watching her hands, watching the gauze come off, watching more and more of my new body come into view. When the last layer peeled away, I looked down at what was left of my right leg.

And I laughed.

I couldn't help it. After all the serious shit — the illness, the addiction, the heart attack, the cancer — here I was, missing a leg, and the damn thing looked like a giant penis. I mean, that's the first thing that popped into my head. I looked at this swollen,

rounded, scarred piece of flesh and thought: *That's the ugliest thing I've ever seen, and I've seen some ugly things.*

Rachel stopped mid-sentence and looked at me.

"Are you okay, John?"

I was laughing too hard to answer. I waved my hand, trying to catch my breath, and finally managed to say:

"I'm fine. I just — it's funny."

She looked at the stump. Looked at me. Looked at the stump again. And then she started laughing too. Not a polite nurse laugh. A real laugh. She shook her head and said:

"I've been doing this job for twelve years, and I've never heard anyone describe it that way."

I said:

"Well, somebody had to say it."

When I told Genie later that day, she laughed even harder than I did. Then she shook her head, wiped her eyes, and said:

"Only you, John. Only you could look at something like that and make a joke."

I told a few close friends. They laughed. I told my daughters the next time they came to visit. They groaned, covered their faces, and told me to stop. My youngest daughter said:

“Dad, that’s disgusting.”

I said:

“It’s not disgusting. It’s honest. And if I can’t laugh at my own body, what can I laugh at?”

She didn’t have an answer for that.

Humor became my coping mechanism. It still is. People ask me how I stay so positive, and I tell them the truth: I’m not always positive. Some days I wake up and the first thing I see when I sit up in bed is that stump. Some days I look at it and feel a wave of anger so hot it surprises me. Some days I’m tired — bone-tired, soul-tired — of dealing with it. But anger doesn’t help. Being pissed off doesn’t put the leg back. So I laugh instead. Because laughing feels better than crying. And because if I can make someone else laugh about it too, then maybe they’ll see that this isn’t the end of the world.

Learning to take care of the stump was a whole education in itself. You have to wash it every day with special soap. You have to dry it thoroughly, because moisture leads to infection, and infection with a residual limb can land you back in the hospital. You have to check the skin for pressure sores, for redness, for any sign that the prosthetic socket is rubbing in the wrong place. You have to put a special liner on it — a gel sleeve that rolls up over the stump like a sock — before you can even think about putting the prosthetic on. The first time I tried to put the liner on myself, I dropped it three times. It kept rolling up on itself like a stubborn tube sock. I sat there on the edge of the bed, liner in one hand, staring at it, and said:

"This is ridiculous."

Genie walked in, picked up the liner, and rolled it onto my stump without saying a word. Then she handed me the prosthetic and said:

"You got the rest?"

I nodded. She walked out. And I sat there thinking: *She's a saint.*

The prosthetic socket rubbing raw — that was a recurring problem in the beginning. The skin on a residual limb is not designed to bear weight. It's soft. Sensitive. It's used to being protected by the rest of the leg. Now suddenly it's pressed against a hard carbon-fiber socket, taking pounds of pressure with every step. The first few weeks, I would walk for maybe ten minutes before the pain became too much. I'd take the prosthetic off and find red marks, blisters, raw spots where the skin had broken down. Carlos, my prosthetist, would adjust the fit. The next day, new spots. It was a constant battle. A constant negotiation between my body and the machine that was supposed to replace what my body had lost.

And then there was the phantom pain.

Nobody warned me about phantom pain. Or maybe they did, and I didn't understand what they meant. You hear the word "phantom" and you think it's going to be subtle. A ghost sensation. A faint memory of a limb that used to be there. That's not what it is. Phantom pain is real pain. Sharp pain. Electric pain. The feeling of a cramp in a muscle that doesn't exist. The feeling of someone driving a nail through a foot that was amputated six months ago. It comes out of nowhere, usually at night, and it leaves you gasping. The first time it hit me, I was

lying in bed, half asleep, and suddenly I felt this searing pain in my right big toe. I grabbed my leg — my good leg — and then remembered that my right foot wasn't there anymore. I sat up in bed, sweating, confused, in agony, and I said out loud:

"That's not possible."

Genie woke up. She asked what was wrong. I told her. She didn't say anything. She just rubbed my back until the pain passed, which it did — slowly, reluctantly, like a guest who didn't want to leave.

The doctors gave me medication for it. Gabapentin. It helped, but it also made me foggy. I had to decide which was worse: the pain or the fog. Most days, I chose the fog. Some days, I chose the pain.

I started meeting other amputees at physical therapy. There was a guy named Mike, about my age, who'd lost his leg to a motorcycle accident. He was six months ahead of me in the process. He could walk with a cane. He could drive. He could climb stairs. I watched him move and thought: *That's going to be me*. We talked one afternoon in the waiting room. I told him I was having trouble with the phantom pain. He nodded like he'd heard it a hundred times before, and said:

"It gets better. Not all at once. But it gets better. You just have to give it time."

I asked him:

"How much time?"

He shrugged and said:

“Different for everybody. For me, it took about a year before I stopped wanting to punch a wall every time it happened.”

A year. I sat with that. A year of phantom pain. A year of socket adjustments. A year of learning how to move through the world in a body that didn't move the way it used to. It sounded like a long time. But I'd already been through so much that a year didn't scare me.

There was one moment, about three months after the amputation, when I was sitting on the back porch, looking out at the yard, and I realized I wasn't thinking about my leg. For the first time since the surgery, I had gone a full hour without thinking about the stump, the prosthetic, the pain, the inconvenience. I was just sitting. Just existing. Like a normal person. I sat there and let that feeling soak in. It was small. It was ordinary. But it felt like a victory.

That's the thing about losing a body part. It doesn't just change how you walk. It changes how you think. It changes how you see yourself. You spend every hour of every day aware of this new reality, like a stone in your shoe that you can't take out. And then one day, you realize you've stopped noticing the stone. Not because it's gone, but because you've learned to walk with it.

Children are the most honest. I had a neighbor's little boy, maybe five years old, come up to me in the driveway one afternoon. He looked at my leg — at the metal pylon and the prosthetic foot sticking out below my shorts — and he pointed and asked:

“What happened to your leg?”

His mother started to apologize. I waved her off. I knelt down — as best I could — and said:

“It got sick, so the doctors had to take it off. But I got a new one. See?”

I tapped the carbon fiber. He stared at it for a second, then looked up at me with the serious expression only a five-year-old can have, and said:

“Cool.”

Then he ran off to play.

Cool. I thought about that word for the rest of the day. That’s the word a kid uses when he sees something he likes. Not scary. Not sad. Cool. Maybe children understand something that adults forget: that life changes, bodies change, and that’s not always a tragedy. Sometimes it’s just different. And different can be cool.

I’ve had people tell me they don’t know how I stay so positive. The truth is, I’m not always positive. Some days I’m angry. Some days I’m tired. Some days I look at my stump and I’m pissed off that this is my life now. But anger doesn’t help. Being pissed off doesn’t put the leg back.

So I laugh instead. Because laughing feels better than crying. And because if I can make someone else laugh about it too, then maybe they’ll see that this isn’t the end of the world.

It’s just a different world.

And you can still find plenty of reasons to smile in it.

11

Chapter 11: Faith

I don't talk about my faith to convince anyone of anything.

I talk about it because it's part of my story, and I can't tell my story honestly without it. I'm not a preacher. I'm not a theologian. I'm just a guy who's been through a lot and came out the other side, and I know — I know — that I didn't do it alone.

There was one night in the hospital that I think about more than any other. It was during the cancer treatments, before the amputation. I was in a room on the third floor, alone, around two in the morning. The nurses had done their rounds. The monitors had been checked. The IV was dripping at its usual pace. Everything was fine, medically speaking. But I couldn't sleep. I was lying there, staring at the ceiling tiles, counting the little holes in them the way you do when you can't turn your brain off.

I was scared.

Not the kind of scared that comes from something specific. The kind of scared that comes from nowhere and everywhere at once. The kind that sits on your chest and makes it hard to

breathe. I thought about my daughters. I thought about Genie. I thought about all the things I hadn't done yet, all the things I might never get to do. I thought about dying. Not in a dramatic, movie-of-the-week way. Just in a quiet, matter-of-fact way. *This could be it, I thought. This could be how it ends.*

And in that moment, I prayed.

I didn't fold my hands. I didn't close my eyes. I didn't kneel beside the bed. I just lay there, looking at the ceiling, and I talked to God the way you'd talk to a friend who was sitting in the room with you. I said:

"I can't do this alone. I need help."

And I felt something.

I can't explain it better than that. I'm not going to tell you the room filled with light or that I heard a voice. I didn't. What happened was quieter than that. It was like a weight lifting off my chest. Like someone had been sitting on me and decided to stand up. I took a deep breath — the first deep breath I'd taken in hours — and the tightness in my throat loosened. The fear didn't disappear, but it moved over. It made room for something else. Something that felt like peace.

I didn't fall asleep right away. But I stopped counting the ceiling tiles. And I stopped being afraid of the dark.

I wasn't raised in a religious household. My family believed in God the way many families do — casually, quietly, without making a big production out of it. We went to church on Easter and Christmas. We said grace before Thanksgiving dinner. We knew the Lord's Prayer well enough to mumble along when the occasion called for it. But faith wasn't something we talked about much. It was just there, in the background, like a radio

playing low in another room.

That changed when my life started falling apart.

It wasn't a dramatic conversion. It wasn't a lightning bolt from the sky. It was slow. Gradual. Each time something went wrong, I found myself reaching for something to hold onto. And the only thing that was always there, the only thing that never ran out or let me down, was the sense that I wasn't alone. I started praying more. Not fancy prayers. Not church prayers. Just honest conversations with God.

Sometimes they sounded like: *What the hell is going on?*

Sometimes they sounded like: *Please let the scan be clear.*

Sometimes they didn't have words at all. Just silence and the hope that Someone was listening.

I believe Someone was.

There were moments during recovery when I was in so much pain I couldn't think straight. After the amputation, the phantom pain would hit at night, and I'd lie in bed with my teeth clenched, gripping the sheets, trying not to wake Genie. In those moments, I couldn't form a coherent thought. I couldn't string together a sentence. But I could still pray. I could still say a single word, over and over, like a mantra: *Help. Help. Help.*

And help came.

Not always the way I wanted. Not always when I thought I needed it. But it came. A nurse would walk in at just the right moment. The pain would subside. Genie would wake up on her own and put her hand on my arm. Nothing miraculous. Just small graces. Tiny reminders that I was being carried.

I had a conversation with a hospital chaplain once. His name was Father Mike. He was an older guy, maybe seventy, with a face that looked like it had seen a lot of suffering and a lot of joy and couldn't quite tell the difference anymore. He came into my

room one afternoon, introduced himself, and asked if I wanted to talk. I said:

"I don't know what to say. I'm not even sure what I believe."

He nodded and said:

"That's a good place to start."

We talked for about an hour. I told him about my life. The drinking. The addiction. The heart attack. The cancer. The leg. He listened without interrupting. When I was done, he said:

"You've been through a lot, John. And you're still here. That's not luck. That's grace."

I didn't know what to say to that. So I just nodded. But I thought about it for a long time after he left. *Grace*. It's a word I'd heard before, but I'd never really understood it. I always thought it meant something you didn't deserve. And maybe that's exactly what it is. I didn't deserve to survive the things I'd been through. I didn't deserve a wife like Genie, daughters who loved me, friends who showed up. But I got it anyway. That's grace.

I remember one specific prayer that I thought was answered in the worst possible way, only to realize later it was answered in the best possible way. When the doctors told me they had to take my leg, I prayed for a miracle. I asked God to save my leg. I begged. I bargained. *If you let me keep my leg, I'll be a better man. I'll go to church. I'll help people. Just let me keep it.* I said that prayer a hundred times. And every time, the answer was

the same. No.

I was angry about that for a long time. I thought God had ignored me. I thought my faith had failed me. But now, looking back, I see it differently. If I'd kept that leg, I would have stayed in constant pain. I would have lost my mobility anyway, just slower and more painfully. The infection could have spread. I could have died. The amputation wasn't a punishment. It was a solution. The prayer was answered — just not the way I wanted it to be answered. I wanted a miracle on my terms. God gave me a miracle on His terms: a chance to keep living.

That's the thing about faith. It doesn't give you what you want. It gives you what you need. And sometimes you don't recognize the difference until years later.

I'm not here to preach. I'm not here to tell you what to believe. But I know this: I should have died a dozen times. I should have given up a hundred times. I should have stayed down after the first blow, let alone the tenth. Something kept me going. Something that wasn't just me.

Call it God. Call it the universe. Call it the human spirit. I don't care what you call it. But I know it's real, because I felt it carry me when I couldn't walk on my own. I felt it in the middle of the night when I was alone and afraid. I felt it in the voice of a nurse, the hand of my wife, the silence of a hospital room at two in the morning.

I don't have all the answers. I don't know why some people get healed and some don't. I don't know why some prayers are answered and others seem to disappear into the void. I don't know why I'm still here when so many good people have gone too soon. I don't know. And I've stopped pretending I do.

But I know this: Faith didn't make the hard things easy. It made them bearable.

I CAN I WILL

And sometimes, bearable is enough.

12

Chapter 12: Family

If you asked me what saved my life, I'd tell you: my family.

Not the doctors. Not the medicine. Not the surgeries or the treatments or the prosthetics. Those things helped. Those things were necessary. But they weren't the reason I kept going when every instinct told me to stop. The reason was sitting in the waiting room. The reason was holding my hand. The reason was driving me to appointments and making sure I took my pills and telling me I was still the same man she married, even when I felt like half of one.

The reason was Genie.

I remember one morning, about two weeks after the amputation. I was in a dark place. The kind of dark where you don't want to talk to anyone, don't want to eat, don't want to get out of bed. I was lying there, staring at the wall, feeling sorry for myself. I heard Genie come into the room. I didn't turn around. She sat down on the edge of the bed, put her hand on my shoulder, and said:

"John. You need to get up."

I said:

"I don't want to."

She said:

"I know. But you need to."

I didn't move. She sat there for a full minute, not saying anything, just letting her hand rest on my shoulder. Then she said something I'll never forget:

*"I didn't marry you for your leg. I married you for you.
And you're still here. So get up."*

I got up.

That was Genie. She never let me wallow. She never let me quit. She was gentle when I needed gentle and tough when I needed tough, and she always knew the difference. She was with me for every surgery, every treatment, every breakdown. She was the one who made sure the bills got paid when I couldn't work. She was the one who talked to the insurance companies, who argued with the doctors, who filled the prescriptions, who cooked the meals I couldn't eat and cleaned up the mess when I couldn't hold them down. She never wavered. Not once.

People say "for better or for worse" at weddings, but they don't really know what "worse" looks like. Genie knew. She lived it. And she never walked away.

My daughters — they were the other reason. Watching them grow into strong, capable women gave me something to fight for when I wanted to quit. I wanted to see their weddings. I

wanted to meet my grandchildren. I wanted to be there for them the way they had been there for me. My oldest daughter, she came to visit me in the hospital after the cancer diagnosis, and she sat in the chair next to my bed with this look on her face — the look of a daughter trying not to cry in front of her father. She said:

“You’re going to be okay, Dad.”

I said:

“I know.”

I didn’t know. But I knew she needed to hear me say it. And sometimes, saying something out loud is the first step toward making it true.

My youngest daughter was the one who made me laugh when I didn’t think I could. She came to visit after the amputation, and she was trying so hard to be normal, to act like everything was fine. She was telling me about her job, about some drama with a coworker, and she was using her hands the way she always does when she talks. She knocked over a cup of water on the nightstand. Water went everywhere. She jumped up, grabbed a towel, and started apologizing. I started laughing. She looked at me like I was crazy. I said:

“You’re still clumsy. That’s good. Some things never change.”

She laughed. And for a few minutes, we were just a father and a daughter, not a patient and a visitor.

My parents came to see me too. My father wasn't the kind of man who said much, but he showed up. He'd sit in the corner of the room, quiet, just being there. Sometimes he'd stay for an hour, sometimes longer. He didn't need to say anything. His presence was enough. My mother would bring food — casseroles, mostly, because that's what mothers do. They bring food. As if a tuna casserole could cure cancer. But it wasn't about the food. It was about the effort. It was about the message: *I'm thinking about you. I care. I'm here.*

My siblings called. My cousins checked in. Friends I hadn't spoken to in years reached out. Some of them I hadn't talked to since before the drinking got bad, but they heard I was sick, and they called. That meant something. It meant that the connections I'd built over a lifetime — even the ones I'd neglected — were still there, waiting to be picked back up.

There was one friend, a guy named Dave, who I'd known since we were kids. We'd drifted apart over the years, the way people do. Life gets busy. You move. You lose touch. But Dave heard about the amputation, and he drove three hours to come see me. He walked into my hospital room with a six-pack of root beer and a deck of cards. He said:

"You look like hell."

I said:

"Thanks. You too."

We played cards for two hours. Didn't talk about the leg. Didn't talk about the cancer. Talked about old times. Laughed about stupid things we did when we were teenagers. When he left, he

shook my hand and said:

“Call me if you need anything.”

I knew he meant it. And knowing that — knowing there was someone out there who would drop everything to come play cards with me in a hospital room — that made more difference than any medication.

I remember a specific moment during the chemo treatments. I was lying on the couch, too weak to move, too nauseous to sleep. Genie was in the kitchen, and I could hear her on the phone with someone. Her voice was low, and I could tell she didn't think I could hear her. She was saying:

“I don't know if he's going to make it. But I'm not going to let him give up.”

I lay there and listened to her talk, and I realized that she was carrying more than I knew. She was being strong for me, but she was scared too. She was fighting her own battle — the battle of watching someone she loved suffer and not being able to stop it. And she never complained. She never said, “This is too hard.” She just kept going. Day after day. Appointment after appointment. Crisis after crisis.

That's love. Not the kind you see in movies. The kind that keeps showing up even when there's nothing in it for you.

My daughter's wedding happened during this whole mess. I was between treatments, and I wasn't sure I'd have the strength to walk her down the aisle. I told her I might need a cane. She said:

"I don't care if you need a walker, Dad. I want you there."

So I went. I wore my best suit. I borrowed a cane from a friend. I walked her down the aisle one slow step at a time, and I didn't cry until I handed her off to her new husband. But I cried then. So did she. So did Genie. So did half the people in the church. It wasn't just a wedding. It was a victory. It was proof that I had made it to a day I wasn't sure I'd ever see.

I learned something through all of this: family isn't about blood. It's about who shows up when everything falls apart. There are people I'm related to who I don't talk to anymore. People who share my last name and my DNA but weren't there when I needed them. And there are people with no blood connection who I'd trust with my life. Dave. Some of the nurses. Carlos, my prosthetist. A few of the guys from my old job who called every week just to check in.

That's the real family. The people who stand beside you when it's hard. The people who don't run when things get ugly. The people who love you not because you're perfect, but because you're theirs.

I've been blessed with a lot of those people. Genie. My daughters. My parents. My true friends. Every one of them played a part in keeping me alive, whether they knew it or not. They were the reason I got out of bed. They were the reason I kept fighting. They were the reason I'm still here, sitting at this keyboard, writing these words.

And I try every day to be that person for someone else. I call my daughters just to say hello. I check on my friends when they're going through hard times. I show up. I don't ask if they need me — I just come. Because that's what family does. Family shows up.

Not because it's easy. Because it matters.

13

Chapter 13: Roxy

The front door had barely cracked open when I heard her. The click-clack of nails on hardwood, accelerating into a skid, and then the full-body slam of forty pounds of dog hitting the door from the inside. She didn't care that I'd been gone for six hours. She didn't care that I was exhausted, that my prosthetic was rubbing raw, that I'd spent the morning in a surgeon's waiting room trying not to think about what the scans might show. She cared about one thing: I was home.

I pushed the door open and she burst through, spinning in tight circles, her tail a blur, her whole hind end wagging so hard she nearly tipped over. She looked up at me with those big brown eyes and I swear she was smiling. Dogs don't smile. But Roxy does.

I crouched down, balanced on my good leg, and let her attack my face with licks.

Alright, alright, I said. I missed you too.

She didn't stop. She never stops. That's the thing about Roxy.

She doesn't hold back. She doesn't play it cool. When she's happy, the whole world knows it. And when she's sad — well, she's never sad. That's the other thing about her. I've never seen that dog have a bad day. Not one. And I've had enough bad days for both of us.

I got her eight years ago, in a roundabout way that I should have seen coming. My daughter — the one who always seems to know what I need before I know it myself — called me up one afternoon.

Dad, she said. You need to come with me somewhere.

I was in the middle of trying to adjust my prosthetic. It had been about four months since the amputation, and I was still figuring out how to make the thing work without destroying the rest of my leg. I was frustrated. I was sore. I was in no mood for errands.

Where? I asked.

Just get in the truck, she said. Don't argue.

So I got in the truck. Because when your daughter talks to you like that, you listen. She drove me out to a farm on the edge of the county. A friend of a friend had a dog who'd had a litter, and the puppies were ready for homes. I didn't know that's where we were going until we pulled into the gravel driveway and I saw a woman standing by a barn with a pen full of wiggling fur.

I don't need a dog, I said.

My daughter looked at me. That look. The one that says: *You*

don't know what you need, but I do.

Just look at them, she said. That's all I'm asking.

So I got out. Walked over to the pen. There were six puppies in there, maybe seven. They were all over each other, biting ears, tumbling over, yapping. All except one. One was off to the side, sitting by herself, watching me. She was the smallest. The runt. Her coat was a little duller, her eyes a little quieter. She didn't bounce around like the others. She just sat there, head tilted, one ear up and one ear down, looking at me like she was trying to figure out who I was and whether I measured up.

I crouched down. She stood up, walked over slowly, sniffed my hand. Then she climbed into my lap. Climbed. Like I was a chair she'd been waiting to sit in. She turned around twice, curled up, and let out a sigh that seemed to come from somewhere deep.

I looked at my daughter. She was already smiling.

She picked you, she said.

I wanted to argue. I wanted to say I wasn't ready. That I didn't have the energy. That a dog was a commitment and I wasn't sure I could commit to anything when my whole life felt like it was held together with tape and stubbornness. But the puppy was already asleep in my lap. Her little ribcage rising and falling. Her paws twitching like she was running somewhere in her dreams.

I took her home. Named her Roxanne, after the song, because I'd always loved that name and because it felt like a name that could grow into something. But she was Roxy from the first day. The runt who climbed into my lap and decided I was hers.

She's not a beautiful dog. I'll be honest about that. She's got

a lopsided face, ears that don't match, a coat that looks like she rolled through a pile of leaves and decided to keep the look. She runs funny, with her back end cocked to one side. When she sleeps, she snores. Loud. The kind of snoring that rattles the windows and makes you wonder if you should check her pulse. But none of that matters. She's the best dog I've ever had. The best dog I'll ever have.

Here's what I mean. There are days when I wake up and everything hurts. The phantom pain. The socket of my prosthetic pressing into flesh that's never quite healed right. The memories that show up whether I invite them or not. Days when I don't want to get out of bed. Days when the weight of everything I've been through sits on my chest like a concrete slab. On those days, I don't have to tell Roxy. She knows. She always knows. She'll come over to the side of the bed, rest her chin on the mattress, and just look at me. No barking. No jumping. Just those big brown eyes, patient and steady, saying: *I'm here. Take your time. But eventually you're going to have to get up and let me out, so maybe don't take too long.*

And then there's the other side of her. The side that saves me in a completely different way. She'll come up to me for no reason, turn around, and look back at her butt like she's trying to communicate a very important message. The message is: *Scratch right here, Dad. Right by the tail. That's the spot.*

And I do. I reach down and scratch that spot above her tail, and her back feet start hopping. Her hips start wiggling. She looks back at me with this look of pure bliss, like I've just solved every problem she's ever had.

I have a whole routine with her. I'll scratch her back and say it slow, in a sing-song voice:

Roxy... Roxanne... scan, scan, scan.

I don't know where the "scan, scan, scan" came from. It just came out one day and it stuck. She doesn't know what the words mean. She doesn't care. She knows it's our thing. She knows that when I say those words, I'm paying attention to her. I'm in the moment with her. Her tail goes crazy. Her whole body wags. She presses into my hand like she's trying to push the scratches deeper into her fur.

Those moments are the ones I don't talk about when people ask me about my story. They want to hear about the survival stuff. The hospital drama. The comeback. And that's all real. But the moments that actually keep me going are smaller than that. They're scratching my dog's butt while she does her happy dance. They're laughing at her snoring. They're watching her chase a squirrel across the yard, knowing full well she's never going to catch it, but watching her run anyway, full speed, no hesitation, like this is the most important thing in the world.

Roxy doesn't care that I'm an amputee. Doesn't care that I've got a prosthetic that squeaks when I walk. Doesn't care that I've been through hell and come out the other side with scars inside and out. She cares that I'm home. She cares that I scratch her back. She cares that I'm here. Not the amputee version of me. Not the cancer survivor version of me. Just me. John. The guy who feeds her and scratches her butt and talks to her in a silly voice.

And some days, that's exactly what I need. A dog who loves me without conditions. Who doesn't want anything from me except my presence. Who doesn't care if I'm having a bad day or a good day or a day I'd rather forget entirely. She just wants to be near me.

There's a lesson in that. I'm not saying dogs are better than people. I'm saying there's something pure about a relationship that has no agenda. Roxy doesn't want my story. She doesn't want my explanation. She doesn't need me to be inspirational or strong or brave. She just wants me to show up. To be present. To scratch the spot by her tail.

Roxy saved me. Not the way a doctor saves you, with medicine and scalpels. Not the way a therapist saves you, with insight and questions. She saved me the way a warm fire saves you on a cold night. She gave me something to come home to. Something that needed me. Something that reminded me, every single day, that joy is still available. That laughter is still an option. That even on the worst days, there's a dog waiting for you, ready to wiggle her butt and hop her back feet and remind you that life is still good.

You just have to be willing to scratch for it.

14

Chapter 14: Never Giving Up

The first time I said it, I was alone.

It was three in the morning, maybe four. The hospital room was dark except for the glow of the monitors and the thin strip of light coming through the blinds from the parking lot. I was staring at the ceiling, trying to remember what it felt like to sleep without machines beeping around me. My leg — what was left of it — was throbbing. The phantom pains had started a few days earlier, and they were worse than anything I'd felt before. My brain kept sending signals to a foot that wasn't there anymore. Itching. Burning. Cramping. I'd reach down to scratch it and my hand would meet empty space and bandages, and for a split second I'd forget. Then I'd remember. And then I'd have to go through the whole thing again — the realization, the grief, the small death of accepting that my leg was gone.

I couldn't sleep. Couldn't eat. Couldn't think about anything except the fact that my life had been ripped apart and I had no idea how to put it back together.

That's when I said it. Not out loud at first. Just in my head. A whisper to myself in the dark:

I can do this. I will do this.

I didn't believe it. Not even a little. But I said it anyway. Because I needed something to hold onto. And those four words were the only thing I had.

I Can. I Will.

People ask me all the time where those words came from. They think there's a story behind them. A moment of inspiration. A teacher who said something. A book I read. A sermon I heard. There's none of that. They came from the bottom. They came from a hospital bed at four in the morning when I had nothing else. No answers. No certainty. No guarantee that things would ever get better. Just those four words, repeated over and over, like a prayer I wasn't sure I believed in.

I said them during chemo, when the poison was dripping into my veins and I could feel it burning through me. I said them sitting on the edge of my bed, staring at my prosthetic, trying to convince myself to put it on and try to stand. I said them in physical therapy, sweat pouring down my face, my arms shaking, my good leg screaming, while the therapist told me I had five more reps and I knew I couldn't do five more and I did them anyway. I said them in the middle of the night, alone, afraid, wondering if all of this was worth it.

I Can. I Will.

It wasn't confidence. I've never been a confident person. Not in the way people think. I didn't walk around believing everything would work out. I walked around terrified, most of the time, pretending I wasn't. And those four words weren't a declaration of certainty. They were a decision. A choice I made every single morning, sometimes every single hour. I chose to keep going. Not because I felt brave. Not because I was strong. Because I had decided that quitting wasn't an option.

Some days I believed the words. Some days I didn't. But I said them anyway. I learned something important in that process: action comes before motivation. Everybody waits to feel ready. Everybody waits for the perfect moment, the surge of inspiration, the lightning bolt of motivation that's going to carry them through. That lightning bolt doesn't come. Or if it does, it doesn't last. What lasts is the habit of showing up. The discipline of doing the thing even when you don't want to. The choice to act your way into feeling, instead of waiting to feel your way into acting.

I had a therapist early on — a guy named Dave, tough old bird, probably sixty-five years old, been in the business for thirty years. He'd seen every kind of trauma, every kind of loss, every kind of grief. I was sitting in his office one afternoon, maybe three months after the amputation, complaining about how hard everything was. How I didn't have the energy. How I didn't see the point. How I felt like I was pushing a boulder up a hill and it kept rolling back down.

He listened. Nodded. Let me finish. Then he leaned forward and said:

*John, you're waiting to feel better so you can start living.
But that's not how it works. You start living, and the
feeling better follows. You don't get ready by waiting.
You get ready by doing. So stop waiting.*

I wanted to punch him. I also wanted to hug him. He was right, and I hated him for it.

That advice changed everything. I stopped waiting to feel ready. Stopped waiting to feel motivated. Stopped waiting for some magical moment when everything would click into place.

I just started. I put on the prosthetic even when I didn't want to. I did the exercises even when I was sore. I showed up to therapy even when I wanted to cancel. I said I Can. I Will. even when every part of me was screaming that I couldn't and I wouldn't.

People ask me how I survived everything. How I made it through the addiction, the heart attack, the cancer, the amputation, the long road of recovery. They want a secret. A formula. Some piece of wisdom they can write down and apply to their own lives.

The answer is boring. It's not inspirational. It's not profound. It's not going to make a good TED Talk.

I just refused to quit.

That's it. That's the whole thing. I was too stubborn to die. Too stubborn to stay down. Too stubborn to let life win.

And that stubbornness — that plain, hard-headed refusal to give up — carried me through every single thing that tried to take me out. Not my intelligence. Not my talent. Not my faith, even, though my faith helped. It was stubbornness. Pure, simple, ugly stubbornness. The kind that looks at a mountain and says: *I'm going to climb you, even if it takes me the rest of my life.*

I think about the people who didn't make it. The ones I met in recovery, in the hospital, in the support groups. Good people. Strong people. People who had every reason to make it. And some of them didn't. Not because they were weaker. Not because they didn't want it enough. Sometimes the mountain is just too high. Sometimes the weight is just too much. I'm not naive about that. I know I got lucky in ways I can't explain. I know there were moments when I was one bad decision away from falling back into the pit.

But I also know this: every single time I wanted to quit, I

didn't. Every single time I thought about giving up, I found a reason to keep going. Sometimes that reason was my daughter. Sometimes it was Roxy. Sometimes it was a verse from the Bible I hadn't thought about in years. Sometimes it was just the memory of a man named Dave telling me that you get ready by doing.

I Can. I Will.

Those two sentences. Those four words. They're not a motto. They're not a brand. They're not something I put on a T-shirt and sell at a speaking event. They're the truth of my life. I can do this. I will do this. Not because I'm special. Because I made a decision. And I kept making it, over and over, every day, for years.

Some days I still have to say them. Even now. Even with all the surgeries behind me and the recovery mostly behind me and the speaking career in front of me. There are still mornings when I wake up and everything feels heavy. When the phantom pains are bad. When the doubt creeps in. When I wonder if I've got anything left to give.

And I say it again. Under my breath. A whisper to myself in the dark:

I Can. I Will.

And I do.

15

Chapter 15: The Lost Limb Riders

The first time I heard about them, I almost didn't go.

It was a Tuesday afternoon, and I was sitting in a support group at the rehab center. One of those mandatory meetings they make you attend after the amputation, where everyone sits in a circle and talks about their feelings. I hated those meetings. I'm not a feelings guy. Not in a group setting, anyway. I'd rather sit in a garage with a buddy and drink a beer and not talk about anything important than sit in a circle and talk about my feelings with strangers.

But I went. Because they told me it would help. And I was desperate enough to try anything.

There was a guy in that group named Mike. Mike was maybe fifty years old, built like a refrigerator, with a gravelly voice and a laugh that sounded like a cement mixer. He'd lost his left arm in a construction accident about ten years before I met him. He was sitting across from me in the circle, wearing a T-shirt that said *Lost Limb Riders* across the front, with a picture of a motorcycle and a skeleton riding it, missing one leg.

I stared at the shirt for half the meeting. Finally, after

everyone was done sharing, I pointed at him and said:

What's that?

He looked down at his shirt like he'd forgotten he was wearing it.

Lost Limb Riders, he said. Group I'm in. Amputees who ride motorcycles.

I snorted. I couldn't help it.

You ride? I asked. With one arm?

He grinned. Held up his prosthetic arm — a hook attachment, old-school, the kind you see in pirate movies.

Damn right I ride, he said. You don't need two arms to work a throttle. You need balance, a good bike, and a stubborn streak. You got any of that?

I told him I had a stubborn streak the size of Texas. He laughed that cement-mixer laugh and said:

Then you should come to a meeting. See what you think.

I took his number. Stuck it in my pocket. Told myself I'd call. I didn't call. Not that week, not the next. Not because I didn't want to. Because I didn't know how to show up to something like that. I wasn't a joiner. I'd never been part of a club, a team, a fraternity. I was a solo operator. Always had been. The idea

of walking into a room full of strangers — amputees, no less — and trying to fit in felt harder than the physical therapy.

But Mike kept showing up at the support group. Every Tuesday. And every Tuesday, he'd look at me and say:

You call that number yet?

And every Tuesday, I'd say:

Not yet.

And he'd say:

You will.

He was right. After about a month, I finally called. I don't know what changed. Maybe I was lonely. Maybe I was curious. Maybe I was tired of sitting in my house feeling sorry for myself. But I called the number, and a woman named Diane answered. She told me they were meeting that Saturday at a diner on the south side of town. Ten o'clock. Breakfast first, then a ride.

I showed up at nine forty-five. Sat in my truck in the parking lot for twenty minutes, trying to talk myself into walking through the door. I almost left three times. I had my hand on the ignition key. I was ready to go home, climb back into bed, and pretend I'd never made the call.

But I thought about Mike. His laugh. His hook hand. The way he said *damn right I ride* like it was the most obvious thing in the world. If he could do it — one arm, ten years after his accident — I could at least walk through a diner door.

So I did.

The first thing I noticed was the laughter. I heard it before I saw anything. I walked in and there was a group of maybe fifteen people in the back corner, pushed two tables together, and they were laughing. Not polite laughter. Not the kind of laughter you do at a work function to be nice. Real laughter. The kind that comes from the gut. The kind that makes you lean back and slap the table. A woman at the end of the table was telling a story about trying to put on her prosthetic leg in a moving car, and by the time she got to the punchline — something about her leg falling out the window at a toll booth — half the table was crying.

I stood there for a second, just watching. They were missing every combination of limbs you could imagine. Arms. Legs. Hands. Feet. Some were in wheelchairs. Some had canes. Some walked fine with prosthetics you'd barely notice if you weren't looking. One guy had a blade runner foot, carbon fiber, the kind you see in the Paralympics. Another guy had a prosthetic arm with a custom-painted skull on the bicep.

And they were laughing. Having breakfast. Living their lives.

Mike saw me standing there and waved me over with his hook.

There he is, he said. The stubborn son of a bitch I told you about.

He pulled out a chair next to him and I sat down. Diane handed me a menu. Someone pushed a pot of coffee toward me. Nobody stared at my leg. Nobody asked awkward questions like *what happened to you?* or *does it hurt?* Nobody treated me like I was broken. They treated me like I was one of them. Because I was. I just didn't know it yet.

I learned a lot that morning. I learned that the Lost Limb

Riders started as a small group of amputee veterans who wanted to keep riding after their injuries. It grew from there. Now it's a national organization, with chapters all over the country. They ride together, raise money for amputee programs, visit people in the hospital who've just lost limbs, and remind each other that life isn't over. It's different. But it's not over.

I learned that Diane lost her leg to cancer when she was twenty-two. She was a college athlete, track and field. She thought her life was over. Now she rides a Harley and runs a nonprofit. The guy with the skull bicep, Jerry, lost his arm in a factory accident. He was a mechanic before. Now he builds custom bikes with modified controls for amputees. The woman who told the story about her leg falling out the window, Sharon, lost both legs below the knee to a blood infection. She rides a trike now, and she's faster than half the people on two wheels.

These were my people. I felt it in my bones.

After breakfast, they asked if I wanted to ride. I told them I didn't have a bike. Mike looked at me like I'd said something ridiculous.

That's what the garage is for, he said. Jerry's got a loaner. Old Honda. Needs some work, but it runs. You ride it today, you figure out if you like it. If you do, we help you find your own.

So I rode. A beat-up Honda with a slightly crooked handlebar and a seat that had seen better days. I followed the group out of the diner parking lot, onto the highway, through the back roads outside town. Fifteen amputees on motorcycles, riding in formation. Some with prosthetics. Some with adaptive controls. All of them moving forward, together.

I won't lie to you. It wasn't easy. My balance was off. My prosthetic leg didn't bend the way a real leg bends, so shifting gears took concentration. I had to think about every movement, every turn, every stop. But somewhere around the third mile, something clicked. The sun was warm. The wind was loud. The road was open. And for the first time in months — maybe years — I felt free.

I felt whole.

Not in spite of what I'd lost. But because of where I was and who I was with. These people understood. They didn't need me to explain. They looked at my prosthetic and they didn't stare. They didn't ask if I was okay. They knew I'd been through hell, because they'd been through their own versions of it. And they were still here. Still riding. Still laughing.

That first ride changed something in me. It gave me a picture of what my future could look like. Not a future of limitation and loss. A future of movement and community and purpose. The Lost Limb Riders became my tribe. We ride together. We support each other. We show up for each other when things get hard. And we visit other amputees — people who are just starting their journey, still raw, still scared, still wondering if they'll ever feel normal again — and we show them what's possible.

That's the thing I didn't know when I lost my leg. There's a whole community of people out there who have been through it. And they're not sitting around feeling sorry for themselves. They're living. They're thriving. They're riding.

Finding the Lost Limb Riders saved my life in a different way than the surgeries did. The surgeries kept me alive. The Lost Limb Riders gave me a reason to stay that way. They gave me a mission. If I could help one person — just one — who just lost their leg see that they can still ride, still laugh, still live, still

love their life — then all of this was worth it.

That's what I tell the new guys now. The ones I visit in the hospital. The ones who look at me the way I looked at Mike that first day in the support group. I tell them:

It's going to get better. Not right away. Not all at once. But it's going to get better. You're going to find your people. You're going to find your ride. And one day, you're going to look back at this moment and realize it was the beginning of something, not the end.

I never thought I'd be the guy saying that. But here I am. A Lost Limb Rider. Riding with my tribe. Moving forward. Not in spite of what I lost, but because of it.

Chapter 16: Speaking to Inspire

I never planned to be a speaker. I never wanted to be a speaker. If you'd told me ten years ago that I'd be standing in front of rooms full of people, telling my story for a living, I would have laughed in your face. I'm not a performer. I'm not a natural storyteller. I'm just a guy who lived through some things and didn't quit. That's not a career path. That's just survival.

But people started asking.

It happened slowly at first. A friend from church asked if I'd come talk to his small group. Just my story, he said. Twenty minutes. Nothing formal. I said yes because I didn't know how to say no. I showed up, stood in front of about twelve people in a church basement, and told them what had happened. The addiction. The heart attack. The cancer. The amputation. The recovery. I talked for maybe fifteen minutes, my voice shaking the whole time, my hands clammy. When I finished, there was a long silence. I thought I'd done something wrong. Then a woman in the front row started crying.

Not sad crying. Not pity crying. The kind of crying that comes from recognition. From seeing yourself in someone else's story.

She came up to me afterward and grabbed my hand and said:

I've been sober for three years, and I've never told anyone how hard it still is. Hearing you talk about wanting to give up — that's what I needed to hear today.

I didn't know what to say. I mumbled something about being glad it helped and walked out to my truck feeling like I'd been hit by a truck. Something had shifted. I didn't understand it yet, but I felt it.

The next request came from a recovery center. A guy I'd met in treatment years before was working there now. He called me up and said:

John, I've got a room full of guys who are right where you were. They're fresh out of detox, they're shaky, they're scared, they don't think they can make it. I need someone to come in and tell them it's possible.

I said yes. I drove to the center, walked through a metal detector, sat in a room with about thirty men in various stages of early sobriety. Some of them looked like they hadn't slept in weeks. Some of them looked like they'd given up before I even opened my mouth. I told them my story — the drinking, the rock bottom, the hospital bed, the long climb back. I kept it simple. No fancy language. No inspirational quotes. Just the truth.

Afterward, a young guy came up to me. He couldn't have been more than twenty-five. He had track marks on his arms and tears in his eyes. He said:

I thought I was too far gone. I thought I'd done too much

damage. But you went through all that and you're still standing. That means I can do it too.

That's when I understood. My story isn't mine. It belongs to everyone who needs to hear it. Every person who's sitting in a dark room wondering if they're going to make it. Every person who's staring at a hospital ceiling at four in the morning, asking God if this is the end. Every person who's looking at their own reflection and not recognizing who they've become. My story belongs to them. I'm just the one who gets to deliver it.

The speaking took off in a way I never expected. Word spread. Other churches asked. Then hospitals. Rehab centers. Corporate events. Nonprofit fundraisers. School assemblies. I went from standing in a church basement in front of twelve people to standing on a stage in front of five hundred. It happened fast. Too fast, sometimes. I'd look out at a crowd and feel the old panic rising — that voice in my head that said: *What are you doing here? You're not a speaker. You're not qualified. You're going to mess this up.*

But I'd take a breath. I'd feel the weight of my prosthetic. I'd think about all the mornings I'd said *I Can. I Will.* when I didn't believe it. And I'd start talking.

Every audience is different. Every speech has to be tailored to the people in front of me. I learned that early. You can't stand up and give the same talk to a group of corporate executives that you give to a room full of people in physical therapy. They need different things. They're in different places.

For a corporate event, I focus on resilience. On showing up when things are hard. On the discipline of getting better every day. I talk about how recovery is like building a business — you don't do it overnight, you do it one rep at a time, one day at a

time, one decision at a time. I talk about the Lost Limb Riders, about community, about not trying to do it alone. The executives nod along because they're thinking about their quarterly targets and their team dynamics. But by the end, half of them are tearing up anyway. Because underneath all the business talk, everyone wants the same thing. They want to know that their struggle matters. That the hard work is worth it.

For a rehab center, everything changes. The energy is different. The room is different. There are wheelchairs and walkers and people in hospital gowns who didn't ask to be there. I don't talk about quarterly targets. I don't talk about business. I talk about the small victories. The first time I stood up. The first time I took a step. The first time I walked across the room without holding onto anything. I tell them:

I walked again. Not because I was strong. Because I was stubborn. I fell down a thousand times and got up a thousand and one. You can do the same thing. It's going to hurt. It's going to be humiliating. Some days you're going to cry. But you're going to get up again. And eventually, that getting up becomes walking. And that walking becomes running.

For a recovery center — addiction, not injury — I take a different approach. I talk about the shame. The rock bottom that you have to hit before you're ready to climb. I tell them:

I know what it's like to hate yourself. I know what it's like to wake up and not remember what you did the night before. I know what it's like to look in the mirror and not recognize the person looking back. That shame is heavy.

It wants to keep you down. But shame doesn't have to be the end of the story. It can be the beginning. You can decide, right now, that you're done. That today is the day everything changes.

I've done dozens of these talks. Hundreds by now, maybe. I've lost count. I've spoken in churches with stained glass windows and in community centers with fluorescent lights that hum. I've spoken in hospital cafeterias and hotel ballrooms and once, memorably, in a VFW hall that smelled like old cigarettes and spilled beer. I've spoken to groups of five and groups of five thousand. And every single time, the same thing happens. Someone comes up to me afterward. A man. A woman. A kid. A parent. They shake my hand. Sometimes they hug me. Sometimes they just stand there, crying, not able to say anything.

And they tell me:

I needed to hear that. Thank you.

Every speech I give ends the same way. I look at the audience. I pause. And I say:

I Can. I Will. And so can you.

I mean it every time. Not because I think life is easy. Not because I think everybody can overcome everything. I know that's not true. Some things break you. Some things take more than stubbornness to fix. But I also know that most of us quit too early. We give up right before the breakthrough. We stop pushing one rep short of the finish line. And that's the tragedy. Not the

failure. The quitting.

If I can stand in front of a room full of strangers, with my prosthetic leg and my scarred history and my shaky voice, and help one person decide not to quit — then every sleepless night, every painful therapy session, every moment I wanted to give up was worth it.

My story isn't mine. It belongs to everyone who needs to hear it. I'm just the messenger. And as long as people keep asking, I'll keep showing up. I'll keep telling the truth. And I'll keep ending the same way.

I Can. I Will. And so can you.

Chapter 17: One Man's Journey

So here I am.

I'm sitting at my desk, looking out the window at a tree I've been watching for three years. It's an oak, maybe a hundred years old, with branches that reach out like arms stretching after a long sleep. I've watched it lose its leaves in the fall and go bare through the winter. I've watched the buds come back in the spring and the full canopy spread in the summer. I've watched it through every season, through every change, through cancer and chemo and amputation and recovery. It's still there. Still standing. Still doing what a tree does.

I like to think I'm a little bit like that tree.

I'm not saying I'm wise or ancient or majestic. I'm saying I've been through a lot of seasons, and I'm still here. Still standing. Or at least, still sitting upright in this chair, with my prosthetic propped against the desk and my dog snoring at my feet.

Roxy is curled up under the desk. She's been there for the last hour, her head on my foot, her body rising and falling with each breath. Every now and then she kicks in her sleep, chasing some dream-squirrel through some dream-yard. I look down at her

and I think about how many times she's been right here, in this exact spot, while I was writing, thinking, crying, laughing, or just staring at the wall trying to figure out how to keep going.

She doesn't care what I'm doing. She just wants to be near me. That's her whole philosophy. Be near. Be loyal. Be present. I could learn a lot from that dog.

I've lived more lives than most people. I don't say that to brag. I say it because it's true, and it's strange to sit with. When I look back at everything I've been through, it feels like I'm looking at a whole shelf of different people, all of whom share my name and my face, but each of whom lived through something different.

There was the young John, the drinking John, the one who showed up to work hungover and spent his nights at the bottom of a bottle. That John was lost. He was angry. He was looking for something to fill a hole he didn't know how to name. He thought alcohol was the answer. It took him years to realize it was the problem.

There was the John who had the heart attack. The one who felt his chest cave in and thought: *This is it. This is how I die.* That John was forty-six years old, lying on a hospital gurney, watching the ceiling lights blur past as they wheeled him into surgery. That John made a promise to God that he wasn't sure he'd keep.

There was the John who got clean. The one who sat in recovery meetings and felt like an imposter. The one who white-knuckled his way through the first year, not because he was strong, but because he was too ashamed to go back to the life he'd left. That John learned that shame can either crush you or push you forward. He chose forward.

There was the John who heard the word *cancer* come out of a doctor's mouth. The John who sat in a small examination

room with bad lighting and a poster about prostate health on the wall, trying to process what the doctor was saying while the words bounced around his head like pinballs. The John who went through chemo, lost his hair, lost his energy, lost his sense of taste, lost everything except the will to keep fighting.

And there was the John who lost his leg. That John woke up from surgery and looked down at a body he didn't recognize. That John spent months learning how to walk again, how to balance, how to navigate a world that wasn't built for people like him. That John cried more times than he'd ever admit. That John also learned something he couldn't have learned any other way: that losing a limb doesn't mean losing yourself.

All those Johns live inside me now. They're not gone. They're not ghosts. They're chapters in a book I'm still writing. Some of those chapters are hard to read. Some of them I'd rather tear out and burn. But I don't. Because they're mine. And because every single one of those Johns — the drunk, the heart attack patient, the cancer survivor, the amputee — every one of them is part of the reason I'm still sitting here today.

I didn't survive any of that alone. I had people who refused to let me go. My family. My daughters, who looked at me with love even when I didn't deserve it. My wife, who stuck with me through all of it — through sickness and health, through poverty and plenty, through the worst days and the long nights. She never once made me feel like a burden. She never once looked at me like I was broken. She looked at me like I was still the man she married, even when I didn't recognize myself.

I had my faith. I don't talk about it a lot, because faith is a private thing for me. But I had moments — lying in a hospital bed, staring at the ceiling, the machines beeping around me — when I felt something bigger than me in the room. I don't know

how to explain it. I don't try. But I know that in the moments when I was too weak to carry myself, something carried me. I've never needed to name it to believe it.

And I had the people I met along the way. The therapists. The doctors. The nurses. The guy in the support group who laughed like a cement mixer and wore a shirt with a skeleton on a motorcycle. The recovery meeting friends who called me when I was struggling and told me to show up, just show up, even if I didn't feel like it. The strangers who came up to me after a speech and told me their own stories, trusting me with their pain because I'd trusted them with mine.

We don't make it on our own. That's something I believe more now than I ever did. We're not meant to. The strong, silent, lone-wolf type — that's a myth. A good story. But the truth is, we need each other. We need someone to scratch our back when we're hurting. Someone to tell us to keep going when we want to stop. Someone to sit in the dark with us until the light comes back.

If you're reading this and you're in the middle of your own fight, I want you to know something. You don't have to be brave. You don't have to be strong. You don't have to have it all figured out. You just have to not quit. That's it. That's the whole thing. Quitting is permanent. Everything else is temporary. The pain — it passes. The fear — it fades. The uncertainty — it clears, eventually. But if you quit, you never get to see what's on the other side.

I've seen the other side. It's worth it.

I'm not saying everything is perfect. It's not. I still have bad days. I still have phantom pains that wake me up at night. I still have moments when I look at my prosthetic and feel a wave of grief for the leg I used to have. I still struggle. I still doubt. I still

wonder sometimes if I've got what it takes to keep going.

But I also have a woman who loves me. A woman who's been with me through all of it and still chooses to stay. I have daughters who make me proud. Daughters who grew into strong, kind, stubborn women who know how to fight for what they want. I have a dog who wiggles her whole back end when I scratch the spot above her tail, who curls up under my desk while I write, who greets me at the door like I've been gone for years even when I've only been gone for ten minutes.

I have a community of amputees who ride motorcycles and laugh too loud and remind me every time I see them that life didn't end when I lost my leg. It changed. But it didn't end.

I have a faith that carried me when I couldn't carry myself. I have a story that isn't mine anymore — it belongs to everyone who needs to hear it.

And I have four words that I say to myself every morning, whether I believe them or not.

I Can. I Will.

I don't know what's next. Life has surprised me enough times that I've stopped trying to predict it. I used to make plans. I used to map out my future and tell myself exactly how things were going to go. Then life came along and showed me that I don't run the show. I don't know if tomorrow will bring a new opportunity or a new challenge. I don't know if my health will hold up. I don't know what the next chapter of this story looks like.

But I know this: whatever comes, I'll face it.

I'll put on my prosthetic. I'll scratch Roxy's back. I'll call my daughters. I'll ride with the Lost Limb Riders. I'll stand in front of a room full of strangers and tell them the truth. And I'll keep saying the same four words, over and over, until I don't need to

say them anymore.

I Can. I Will.

And you can too.

Acknowledgments

No one survives life's hardest moments alone.

Looking back on this journey, I realize that every chapter of this book bears the fingerprints of people who refused to let me give up. Their kindness, strength, patience, and love carried me farther than I ever could have gone by myself.

To my wife, Genie—thank you for standing beside me through every diagnosis, every surgery, every setback, and every victory. You never stopped believing in me, even when I stopped believing in myself. You carried burdens I never fully saw, and you did it with a strength that still amazes me. I love you more than words can ever say.

To my daughters—thank you for giving me reasons to fight on the days when I didn't think I had another fight left in me. Watching you grow into the women you are today has been the greatest blessing of my life. You have made me proud every single day.

To my parents—thank you for teaching me the value of hard work, honesty, perseverance, and showing up. Everything I became was built on the foundation you gave me. I hope I've honored your example.

To my family and friends—thank you for every visit, every phone call, every prayer, every meal, every laugh, and every act of kindness. You reminded me that I was never fighting alone.

To the Lost Limb Riders—you gave me far more than a place

to ride. You gave me a brotherhood and a family. You showed me that losing a limb doesn't mean losing your identity, your freedom, or your joy. Thank you for reminding me that life doesn't end after amputation—it simply begins a different chapter.

To Roxy—my faithful companion, my daily reminder to laugh, and the happiest soul I've ever known. Thank you for greeting me like I was the greatest person in the world every time I walked through the door. Thank you for reminding me that unconditional love really does exist.

To every doctor, surgeon, nurse, prosthetist, therapist, counselor, recovery sponsor, and medical professional who cared for me—thank you for your skill, your compassion, and your patience. Many of you will never know the impact you had on my life, but I carry it with me every day.

To every audience that has listened to my story, every person who waited after a speech to share their own journey, and every stranger who trusted me with their pain—thank you. You've taught me that our stories matter most when they're shared.

Finally, to you, the reader.

Thank you for giving me your time and your trust. I hope that somewhere in these pages you found a reason to believe in yourself a little more than you did before you opened this book.

If my story has reminded even one person to keep going, then every difficult mile was worth walking.

I Can.

I Will.

And so can you.

— **John Thompson**

Afterword

When I first began telling my story, I never imagined it would become a book.

I was simply trying to make sense of everything that had happened. The addiction. The heart attack. The cancer. Losing my leg. Losing people I loved. Learning how to walk again. Learning how to live again.

Somewhere along the way, I realized this story wasn't just about me anymore.

It was about every person who's ever sat in a hospital room wondering what comes next.

Every husband or wife who refused to leave when life got hard.

Every parent trying to find the strength to keep going for their children.

Every addict wondering if recovery is really possible.

Every amputee looking at a prosthetic for the first time.

Every survivor carrying scars that nobody else can see.

If this book found its way into your hands at exactly the right moment, then maybe that's why I was meant to write it.

I can't promise that life gets easier.

I can't promise you'll never be knocked down again.

I can't promise you'll always understand why hard things happen.

What I can promise is this:

You are stronger than you think.

You are capable of more than you know.

And no matter how many times life puts you on the ground,
you still get to decide whether you stay there.

I've learned that courage isn't the absence of fear.

It's taking the next step while you're still afraid.

Hope isn't pretending everything will be okay.

It's choosing to believe that today doesn't get the final word.

And strength isn't found in never falling.

It's found in getting back up one more time.

If my journey has taught me anything, it's that the greatest
victories in life aren't always the biggest ones. Sometimes
they're the quiet victories that nobody else sees.

Getting out of bed.

Taking one more step.

Making one more phone call.

Choosing one more day.

If that's where you are today, I'm proud of you.

Keep going.

One step.

One day.

One decision at a time.

I've lived long enough to know that storms always end.

The sun always comes back.

And as long as you're still breathing, your story isn't over.

Thank you for spending a part of your journey with me.

Now it's time to continue yours.

I Can.

I Will.

And so can you.

— John Thompson

About the Author

John Thompson is a husband, father, grandfather, amputee, cancer survivor, heart attack survivor, and person in long-term recovery whose life has been shaped by resilience, faith, and an unwavering refusal to give up.

Over the course of his life, he has faced challenges that tested him physically, emotionally, and spiritually. He has battled serious illness, overcome addiction, survived a heart attack, endured the amputation of his right leg below the knee, and rebuilt his life one step at a time. Through every setback, he discovered that courage isn't about never falling—it's about getting back up.

Today, John shares his story with churches, hospitals, recovery programs, schools, businesses, and community organizations, encouraging others to find hope in the middle of hardship. His message is simple: no matter what life takes from you, it can never take your ability to choose your next step.

When he isn't speaking, John enjoys spending time with his wife, Genie, his daughters, his family, his faithful dog Roxy, and riding with the Lost Limb Riders, a community that reminds him every day that life doesn't end after loss—it simply takes a different road.

John believes that faith, family, perseverance, laughter, and honest conversation can carry people through even life's darkest seasons.

This is his first memoir.

I Can. I Will. isn't just the title of his story.

It's the promise he made to himself.

And the promise he hopes every reader makes to themselves.

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